

Mauritius

BASALT

Child of Fire, Tempered by the sea, Hardened in Spirit, Timeless in Strength.



To my family.

*The basalt beneath my feet and the anchor of my identity.
The island is my home, but you are my foundation.
Everything I am, I owe to the paths you carved before me.
I am the sum of your stories.*

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Responsable éditorial
Alizée Labonne

Conception graphique
Alizée Labonne & Lily Vaudequin

Edition et vérification des faits
xxxxxx

Recherche iconographique
Alizée Labonne

DROITS
xxxxx
xxxxxxxxxx
xxxxxxxxxx

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ISBN XX
Depot légal : Date

Imprimé en xxxx

Nom de la maison d'édition

Alizée Labonne



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EDITO

*Bronze tells us who ruled,
Basalt tells us who survived*

Basalt is born when lava meets the ocean. It is one of the most durable and unyielding rocks found on Earth's surface. I have always felt that this dark, porous stone is the truest mirror of the Mauritian soul. We are not made of smooth, imported marble; we are volcanic. We are textured by survival, cooled by the Indian Ocean, and forged into something uniquely resilient.

When I began gathering the fragments for this magazine, my goal wasn't to write a definitive encyclopedia of Mauritius. I sought to map our very foundations, looking for a true reflection of who we are. If you have opened these pages in search of the glossy, sun-drenched beaches found in travel brochures, you will need to look elsewhere. BASALT is not a postcard, it is an excavation. We are less interested in the pristine white sands packaged for the external world, and more captivated by the complex, unpolished DNA of the island and its people.

For too long, the narrative of our nation has been frozen. It has been locked in the cold marble of colonial statues, cast in the heavy bronze of 'Great Men', and neatly bound within the dust of official schoolbooks. We walk past these monuments every day in the heart of Port-Louis. They stand tall, unblinking, immune to the tropical sun and the salt of the Indian Ocean. They demand our reverence.

But I found myself wondering: do they tell our truth?

History is a curated archive of treaties, independence dates, and political handshakes. Yet, deep down, we know that the true heartbeat of Mauritius pulses elsewhere. It does not beat in the metal of a monument, but in the fragile, shifting spaces of our daily lives.

*Who truly tells the story
of a nation?*

Is it the political architect who drafts the constitution, or the fisherman feeding the village? Is it found in the paintings of Malcolm de Chazal or in the resonance of a ravanne? Does our culture live on the wooden bench of a fading boutique, or is it being rewritten by the digital youth on their smartphones at Bagatelle Mall ?

This magazine is born from these quiet observations. It is an exploration of the 'Choc des Époques': a subtle, continuous collision between the solemn heritage we inherited and the hyper-connected world we are navigating.

When we juxtapose the ink of our oldest writers with the selfies of today's youth, we are not looking for contradiction. We are not judging what is lost. We are observing continuity. We are watching how the DNA of our island mutates, survives, and gracefully reinvents itself.

*WE ARE
STORIES*

BEFORE

*WE ARE
HISTORY*



To accurately map this reality, we had to blur the traditional lines of journalism. While the sociological truths, historical anchors, and cultural reflections within this magazine are absolute, we have embraced the freedom of narrative staging. Several articles within these pages utilize fictional frameworks, composite archetypes, and recreated dialogues to capture a deeper essence. We are not altering the truth; we are simply designing a sharper lens through which to observe it.

BASALT does not claim to define what Mauritius is. Instead, it is a deeply intimate investigation into what Mauritius has made of us. It is an attempt to map the hybridity, the scars, and the unspoken grace of our people.

In compiling these pages, I realized that editing this magazine was more than an act of journalism; it was an act of personal archaeology. By digging through the layers of our culture, I found pieces of myself.

Qui écrit le récit national ? We do.

The grandmothers, the athletes, the politicians, the fishermans, and the youth. Our identity isn't a pedestal to be stared at; it is water, constantly taking a new shape. It is a living, breathing dialogue. It is time we step out of the shadow of the statues, embrace the basalt beneath our feet, and finally dare to write ourselves.

There is no need to write a new history; the truest monument is the quiet, messy, and beautiful stories we write ourselves.

Alizée Labonne

The Hybrid Pulse

History is rarely a straight line; it is a double exposure. For every official date carved into the marble of a nation, there is a quiet, erratic rhythm beating in the shadows. This timeline is not a history lesson. It is an observation. A brief look at the chronological skeleton of the island, immediately shadowed by the visceral, lived reality of its people.

1835 | THE SILENT BEAT

The abolition of slavery is formalized. A date etched into administrative ledgers and imperial decrees, granting freedom on paper.

Within the sugarcane estates, the ravanne beats out a rhythm of physical survival like a whispered rebellion. The island's soul takes its first, syncopated breath.

1968 | THE FIRST DANCE

March 12, 1968. Independence is declared. A new flag is hoisted as a nation is officially born. In the smoky dancings of Curepipe, musical genres collide. Europeans, Creoles, and Asians share the same dancefloor, searching for an anthem of a hybrid identity.

The sugar empire reaches its zenith. The island operates as a well-oiled factory driven by cane, sweat, and colonial commerce.

A young Malcolm de Chazal looks at a mauritian flower and sees a human face; he looks at a mountain and sees a sleeping giant. This births a metaphysical, hallucinatory gaze that will forever enchant the landscape and the literary voice of the island.

1920 | THE AWAKENING GAZE

1992 | THE MAGNETIC BOND

The Republic is established. The final constitutional ties to the British Crown are severed, leaving the island to stand alone as a sovereign state.

It is the golden age of «cassette culture». From the bustling market of Quatre-Bornes to the Sunday picnics under the filao trees, a shared soundtrack binds the people together, quietly erasing social borders through sound.

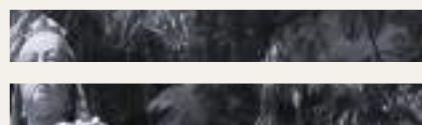
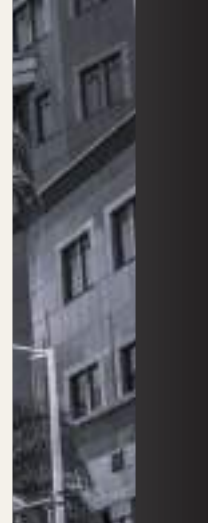
The student strikes swell in the streets of Port-Louis. The youth paralyze the capital, demanding a new dawn for education and equality.

From this unrest, Sega engagé rises. The Creole language steps out of the 'patois' stigma to finally claim its rightful place. The guitar strings vibrate with the beautiful, raw anger of a generation finding its voice.

1975 | THE TONGUE UNTIED

A digital civic awakening ignites. The physical borders of the island vanish as locals and the diaspora unite online. The Mauritian flag transforms into a hashtag, an emoji, and a collective cry of belonging across millions of screens.

2020 | THE DIGITAL REEF



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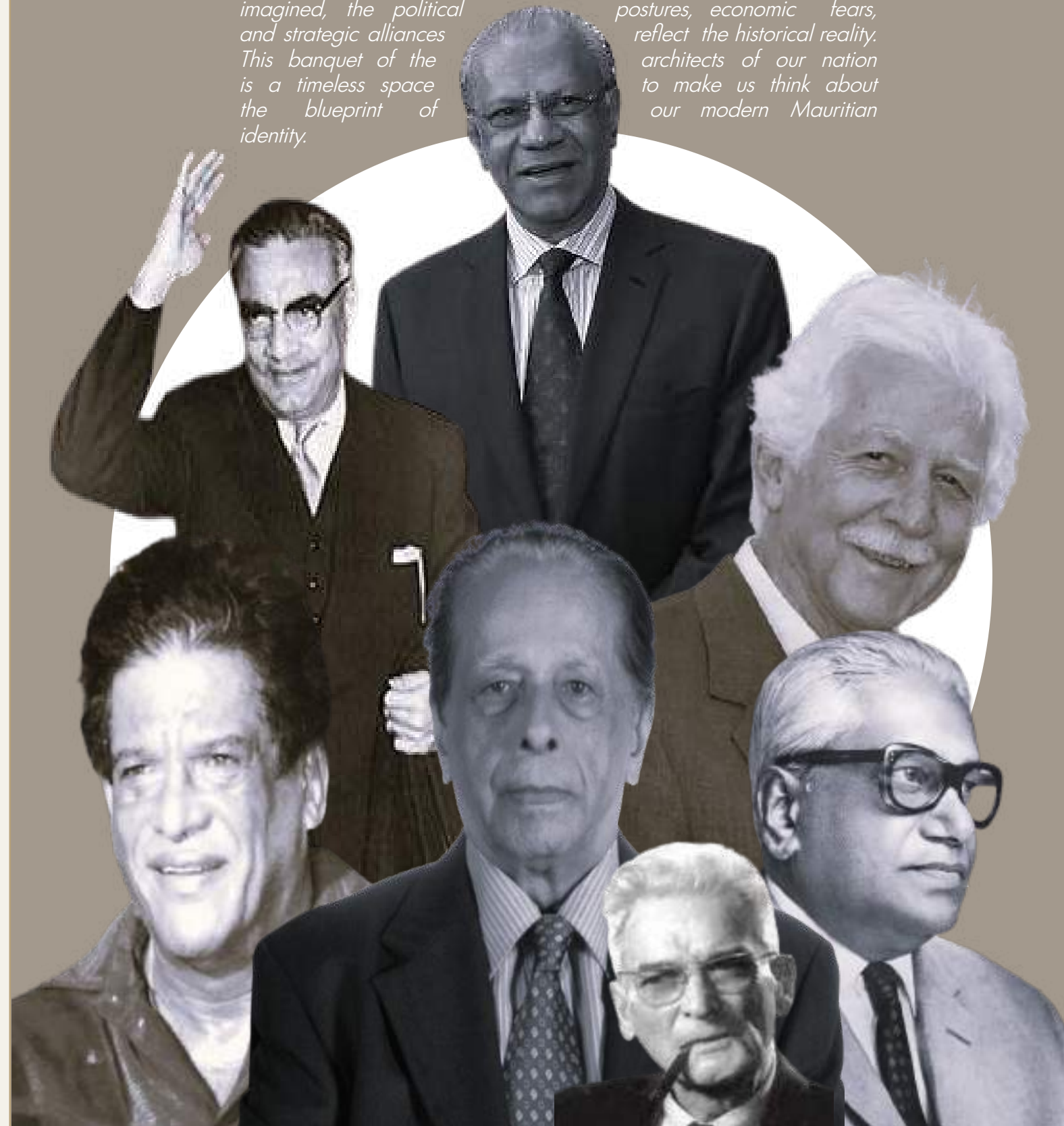
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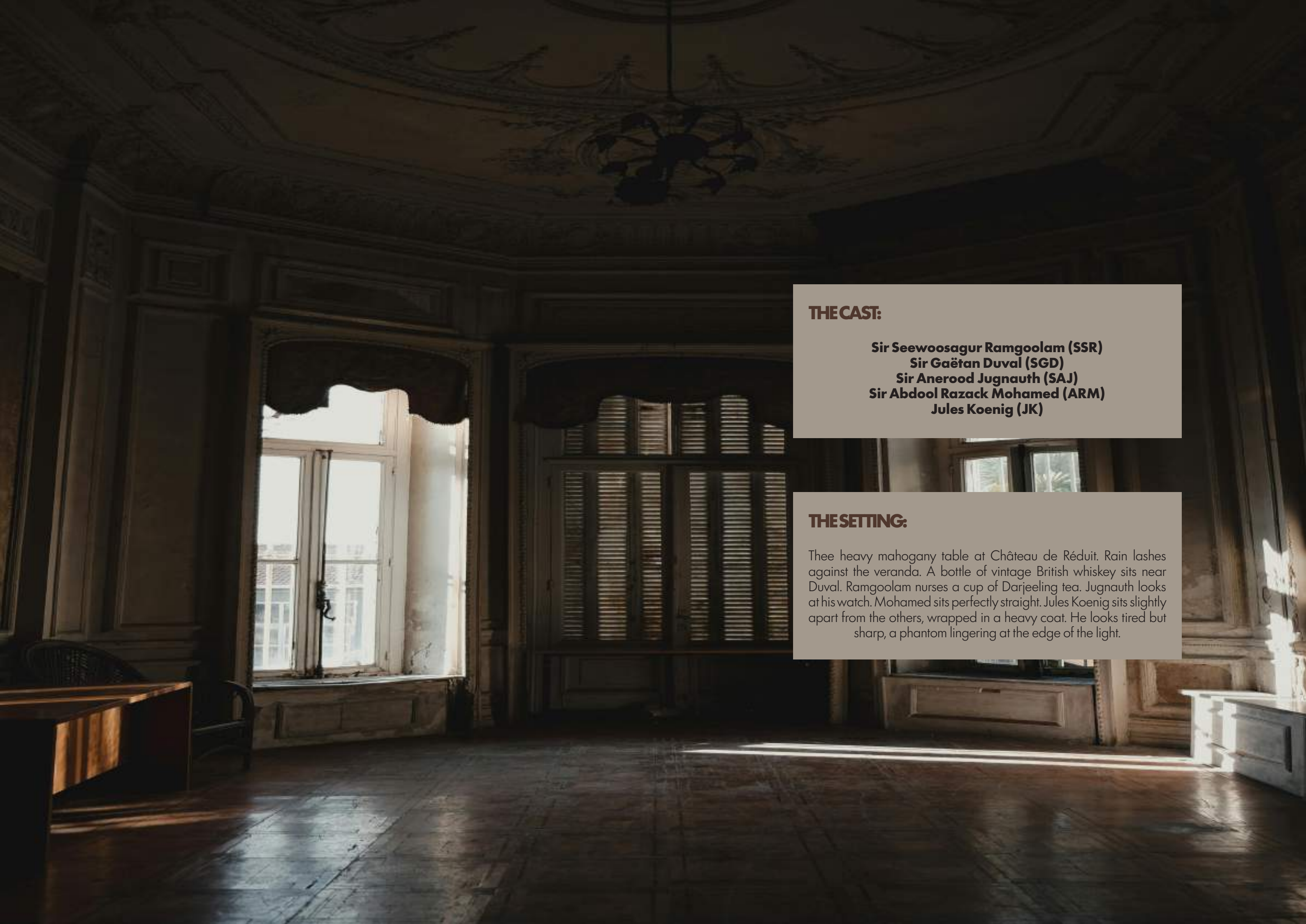
The Founders' Banquet

What happens when the architects of Mauritius sit at the same table to dissect the nation they built?

*While the words spoken
imagined, the political
and strategic alliances
This banquet of the
is a timeless space
the blueprint of
identity.*

*in the following dialogue are
postures, economic fears,
reflect the historical reality.
architects of our nation
to make us think about
our modern Mauritian*





THE CAST:

Sir Seewoosagur Ramgoolam (SSR)
Sir Gaëtan Duval (SGD)
Sir Anerood Jugnauth (SAJ)
Sir Abdool Razack Mohamed (ARM)
Jules Koenig (JK)

THE SETTING:

Three heavy mahogany tables at Château de Réduit. Rain lashes against the veranda. A bottle of vintage British whiskey sits near Duval. Ramgoolam nurses a cup of Darjeeling tea. Jugnauth looks at his watch. Mohamed sits perfectly straight. Jules Koenig sits slightly apart from the others, wrapped in a heavy coat. He looks tired but sharp, a phantom lingering at the edge of the light.

ACT 1: THE 1968 GAMBLE

SSR, *smiling gently, stirring his tea*: — You still drink the British whiskey, Gaëtan. Even after all these years, you refuse to let the Empire go.

DUVAL, *lighting a cigar*: — I don't hold on to the Empire, Seewoosagur. I hold on to quality. And in 1968, you were trying to sell us a very cheap illusion. You were handing the keys of a sinking ship to people who didn't know how to swim.

KOENIG, *leaning forward, his aristocratic voice cutting through the smoke*: — He is right, Seewoosagur. You called it freedom. I called it economic suicide. Without the British safety net, our sugar was worthless. I didn't campaign against Independence because I hated this island; I campaigned against it because I didn't want to see it starve.

SAJ, *interrupting, impatient*: — Both of you, stop being dramatic. The British were done with us. Jules, you were terrified of Independence because you were terrified of losing your oligarchy's privileges. It had to be done.

SSR: — I had to give the people a reason to believe, Anerood. James Meade's report in 1961 said Mauritius was doomed. Overpopulated. Dependent on cane. Independence was the only way to rewrite our fate.

KOENIG: — Belief doesn't feed a family! In 1967, I warned them. And look what happened just months before the flag went up. Brother killing brother in the streets of Port-Louis. We needed British troops just to stop the slaughter. You call that hope?

MOHAMED, *his voice cold and commanding*: — We survived it because of strategy, Jules, not hope. You all built nothing without my signature. I looked at the riots. I knew that if the minorities didn't have guaranteed seats, your 'Independence' would have burned to the ground in a week. I gave SSR the numbers, but I extracted a price: stability.



ACT 2: THE ARCHITECTURE OF BLOOD

MOHAMED: — A rainbow is beautiful, gentlemen, only because the colors do not bleed into one another. I built the borders that kept us from tearing each other apart. The Best Loser System ensured no community would be locked out.

SAJ, *tapping the table:* — And you institutionalized communalism! You made it illegal to just be ‘Mauritian’. Every candidate has to categorize their ancestors like cattle. How can you build a modern republic when you divide the pie by ethnicity before you even bake it?

MOHAMED: — Meritocracy is a luxury for homogeneous nations, Anerood. In a divided society, it is often just a polite word for the tyranny of the majority.

KOENIG, *nodding slowly:* — Razack is right, Anerood. I fought for integration to protect the minorities from being swallowed whole. But my time... my time was up.»

(Koenig slowly sets his glass down. He closes his eyes and leans back into the shadows. He died in May 1968, just weeks after Independence. From this point on, he is a silent phantom, watching the island outlive his darkest fears.)

SSR: — We had to buy the peace. But the true unifier wasn’t the constitution; it was the welfare state. When a child goes to a free hospital, the doctor does not ask for his community. I leveled the playing field.»

DUVAL, *pouring another glass:* — Very poetic. You gave them free education so they could read the unemployment statistics in the 1970s. You built the schools, Chacha, but you forgot to build the jobs.»

ACT 3: THE MIRACLE AND THE SWEAT

SAJ, *eyes flashing with fierce pride:* — Which is why I had to clean up the mess. Philosophy does not fix a balance of payments deficit. When I took over in the 80s, the country was bankrupt.

SSR: — You inherited the literate workforce I created.

SAJ: — I inherited a workforce that was striking! I brought discipline. I expanded the Zone Franche. I told the women of this country to leave the cane fields and step into the textile factories. Sweat and sewing machines. I didn’t just build the roof, Seewoosagur. I built the engine.

DUVAL, *smirking:* — Oh, please. You built the sweatshops; I built the dream. While you argued with union leaders, I brought Brigitte Bardot to our beaches. I convinced the world we were a five-star paradise. You can’t sell a country on discipline alone; you have to sell glamour.

(Koenig’s ghost watches in silent astonishment as his flamboyant protégé, Duval, sells the very island Koenig thought was doomed.)

SAJ: — And I made sure the roads to your hotels were paved, Gaëtan. We formed an alliance in ‘83 because we had to. We didn’t have to like each other. We just had to work.

MOHAMED: — You both commodified the island. Seewoosagur and I built a home. You two turned it into a business.

ACT 4: THE CONCRETE HORIZON

(The rain outside slows. Through the window, the distant, glowing skyline of modern Port-Louis and Ebène flickers.)

DUVAL, *looking out, his voice quiet*: — Look at it. They paved over the poetry. Smart Cities, gated communities for wealthy expats. The beaches I promoted are now walled off from the very people who live here. We sold the dream so well that Mauritians can no longer afford to buy it.

SAJ: — It is called development, Gaëtan. We have the Metro Express. We have foreign reserves. The youth don't break their backs in the cane fields anymore. They work in glass towers.

SSR: — But do they own the towers, Anerood? Or are they just answering phones for people sitting in Paris and London? I gave them free education so they could be masters of their fate, not bilingual servants.

MOHAMED: — The social fabric is fraying. Look at the Wakashio oil spill in 2020. The state failed them, but the real nation stepped up, weaving sugarcane leaves to save their lagoons. Perhaps they don't need us anymore.

DUVAL: — They leave. Look at the brain drain. They take the free education Seewoosagur gave them, and they go build other countries.

SSR, *slowly standing up. He looks at the other three, then glances at Koenig's silent ghost, before looking out toward the dark ocean*: — We were architects, gentlemen. We took a divided, fearful rock, and we built a shelter. We used the mortar of communalism, the bricks of compromise, and the sweat of our people. We gave them a country. A miracle, they called it.

(He pauses, the clinking of Duval's glass the only sound).

I just wonder... in this paradise of concrete and fiber optics we left behind, if they still know how to live in it together.

The lights over the mahogany table fade to black. The rain starts again.





The Builder's Routine

A Day in the Life of SAJ

Behind the iron will that industrialized an island lay a quiet, almost monastic routine. We know the economic miracle he engineered, but how did the man himself sustain the relentless weight of his own ambition? To understand the builder, we must first look at his foundation. Here is the private rhythm, the silent mechanics, of Sir Anerood Jugnauth.

The Morning Routine

- The Grounding | SAJ starts every single day with morning prayers to ground himself amid the noise of the nation. 07:30 AM
- The Island Fuel | a mauritian breakfast awaits : bread, black tea, and fruits (in december lychees and mangoes). 08:00 AM
- The Intel | you cannot rule what you do not know. Local newspapers cover the breakfast table . 08:30 AM

The Lucky Charms

- The Gold Bracelet | a constant companion on his wrist.
- The Heavy Ring | an anchor on his finger.

The Weekend Reset

- The Sanctuary | if the weekdays belong to the Republic, the weekends are surrendered to the bloodline because family is not a duty; it is the sacred ground of our identity.
- The Breath | the boundless energy to «work, work, and work some more» comes from the silent discipline of Yoga. To build a nation is to first master the body.

A Dialogue of Senses:

The Architects of Our Collective Imagination

A nation is not built on laws and concrete alone; it is founded on the myths it tells itself. Before we could fully articulate our political identity, we had to learn how to see our own landscape. Here, the vivid, hallucinatory strokes of Malcolm de Chazal meet the elemental, crashing verses of Robert Edward Hart.

One stripped the island down to its rawest, most vibrant colors; the other anchored it in the heavy, ancient rock of the Indian Ocean. They are not merely artists; they are the founding fathers of the Mauritian soul. Step into the gallery, and watch the island's true skeleton take shape.

'La mer retentissante et les plages sonores
Dialoguent comme l'amour et l'amitié
Autour de la forêt vaste où les cocotiers
Tamisent la lumière entre leurs palmes d'or.'

— Robert Edward Hart, '*Palmeraie*'



Conférence des poissons, Malcolm de Chazal

The Living and Communication Sea

The Poet: In his collections '*Mer Indienne*' and '*L'Ombre étoilée*', Hart constantly evokes the ocean as an entity endowed with language. He writes of '*the resounding sea and the echoing beaches*' and listens closely to the '*musical sea*'.

The Visual Translation: Chazal answers this call through his aquatic gouaches, most notably his famous piece '*Conférence des poissons*' (Conference of the Fishes).

The Artistic Synergy: Hart perceives the sea not merely as a scenic backdrop, but as a murmuring, animated force engaged in a continuous 'dialogue'. Chazal takes this metaphysical idea quite literally: he paints marine creatures not as simple animals, but as highly conscious beings. Equipped with human-like gazes, these fishes appear to be holding a solemn underwater 'council'. Ultimately, Hart's 'musical sea' finds its perfect visual incarnation in Chazal's ocean, which teems with colorful, communicative intelligences.

The Lemurian Myth and the Animated Stone

The Poet: In his majestic prose 'La Montagne fée', Hart searches for divinity within the rock itself, praising the 'Protective Deity' of his land as an 'instruction of Nature' and a 'sign of the divine'.

The Visual Translation: Chazal visually manifests this through his numerous representations of Mauritian peaks, such as the Pieter Both or Morne Brabant.

The Artistic Synergy: It is here that the Lemurian influence strikes hardest. Hart's concept of the 'fairy mountain' implies that Mauritian geology conceals divine spirits and slumbering ancient giants. When observing Chazal's painted mountains, one immediately notices the absence of straight lines. The rock undulates and pulsates with life, and the mountain crests form cleverly hidden human profiles. Hart whispered the secret of this mineral *Protective Deity* into Chazal's ear, and Chazal brought it to life, painting the mountain as a massive, breathing body.

'Elle est une montagne fée, jaillie tout droit de la plaine, noble de profil, aux incurvations harmonieuses. À son versant septentrional, une silhouette d'homme est étendue, qui ressemble à un roi gisant mort sur un lit de parade.'

— Robert Edward Hart, 'La Montagne fée'



Landscape, Malcolm de Chazal



Dodo, Malcolm de Chazal

'Redeviens un petit enfant
Si tu veux voir les choses vierges
Danser parmi la lumière
Du soleil et de la lune.'

— Robert Edward Hart, *'Les enfants
ont sauvé le monde'*

The Return to Eden and the Gaze of Childhood

The Poet: In Chanson XVI, Hart issues a metaphysical directive to his reader: *'Become a little child again / If you want to see virgin things / Dance among the light / Of the sun and the moon.'*

The Visual Translation: Chazal embraces this vision in his utopian depictions of flora and fauna, particularly in his 'Oiseaux-fées' (Fairy-birds) and his paintings of the mythical, extinct Dodo.

The Artistic Synergy: Hart's poem demands that we unlearn our rigid adult rationality; to truly understand the essence of the solar world, one must reclaim the pure, immediate, and unfiltered gaze of a child at the dawn of creation. Chazal applied this very precept to his pictorial technique. He deliberately rejected academic rules, discarding perspective and spatial depth in favor of a consciously 'naïve' art form. By utilizing arbitrary colors like painting yellow skies and blue trees, he transforms nature into a peaceful Garden of Eden. Through his canvas, Chazal paints the exact solar and 'virgin things' that Hart so deeply yearned for.

AVibrant, Ancient Inheritance

Trying to piece together the beautiful, sometimes chaotic mosaic of our identity, it's so easy to get lost tracing the ships, the sugarcane fields, and the ocean crossings of our ancestors. Yet, there is a gentle, almost bittersweet humility in realizing that our story didn't actually start with us.

The island was already dreaming.

That's what Robert Edward Hart heard and Malcolm de Chazal saw. Looking at Chazal's radiant, rule-breaking gouaches, you can't help but smile. Because in those wild, arbitrary strokes,

he wasn't just painting a lost Eden, he was painting us. We are those loud, brilliant colors. We are the warmth, the stubborn joy, and the vibrant, overlapping blend of a people who refuse to fade into the background.

The stone, the sea, and the soil possess a living soul, vibrating with the very same bright, resilient spirit that we carry today, long before we ever arrived. After all, the greatest mystery of our identity might just lie in Chazal's own realization: we did not shape this island; the island, in all its wild and living colors, shaped us.



Before we turn the page on the architects of our Republic, we must pause and listen to the street. For decades, the faces of our founding fathers have secured the weight of our economy. But does the cold marble of official history still resonate with the generation inheriting the island? In this brief Kozé du Coin, we step away from the mahogany tables of power to ask Mauritians a simple question:

The New Currency

This is how the street answered.



Kinsley, 50

Lucinda, 45

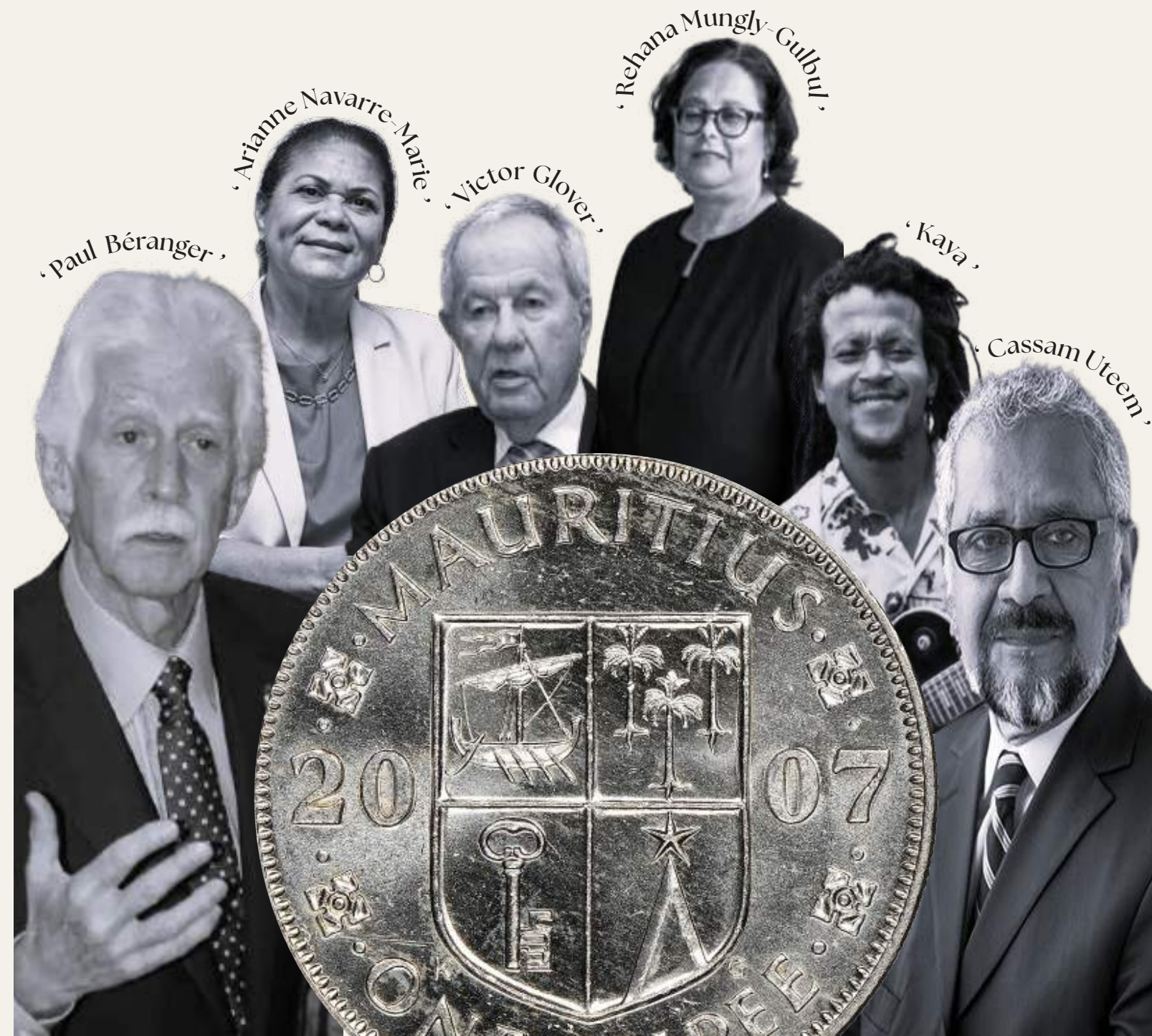
Renaud, 78

Mathieu, 25

Shirley, 70

Christophe, 35

If you Could Redesign our Wealth,
Whose Face Would you put on a
Banknote?



From the Fist To the Pen

A Century of Mauritian Anger

From the dust of the 1937 sugarcane fields to the quiet, intersectional frontlines of today. How the island's struggle mutated from a clenched fist to a sharpened pen. An investigation into the architecture of our revolts through three titans of resistance: Emmanuel Anquetil, Jack Bizlall, and Lindsey Collen.

There is a gentle narrative often woven for the global eye: the idyllic island. A serene haven of white sands and effortless tranquility. Yet, this postcard image tells only half the story. Beneath the calm, this island was forged by a deeper, unyielding resilience. The paradise we see today exists because its people, generation after generation, learned to quietly and powerfully carve their space within it.

Over the last century, the anatomy of this strength has evolved. The endurance that once rooted itself in the soil migrated to the hum of industry, and eventually, into the realm of ideas. The challenges have shifted from historical hardships to the complex currents of the modern world. Yet, the core pulse remains identical: the pursuit of self-determination. To truly understand the Mauritian DNA, one must trace the genealogy of its resilience. We must observe how raw survival slowly transformed—from calloused hands shaping the earth, to voices finding their resonance, and ultimately, to the enduring power of the pen.

Emmanuel Anquetil & the Clenched Fist

The Context: The Hooper Commission era (1937–1938)

The Weapon: The Physical Body.

August 1937. Union Flacq. The heat was a physical weight, cracking the soil and the men who worked it. The laborers possessed nothing; no legal standing, no minimum wage, no voice in the colonial machinery. Paid in copper and treated as extensions of the scythe, they were dismissed by British Governor Sir Bede Clifford as ‘primitive’.

Enter **Emmanuel Anquetil** (1885–1946). He was not a politician; he was an architect of the island’s first collective reflex. Returning from 39 years at sea and in the industrial heart of England, he looked at the bruised, divided laborers and introduced them to the most dangerous concept in the colonial dictionary: ‘Union’. Alongside figures like Dr. Maurice Curé, his rallying cry, *‘Travailleurs, debout !’*, acted as an electric shock to the island’s spine. It was an awakening that transcended community lines.

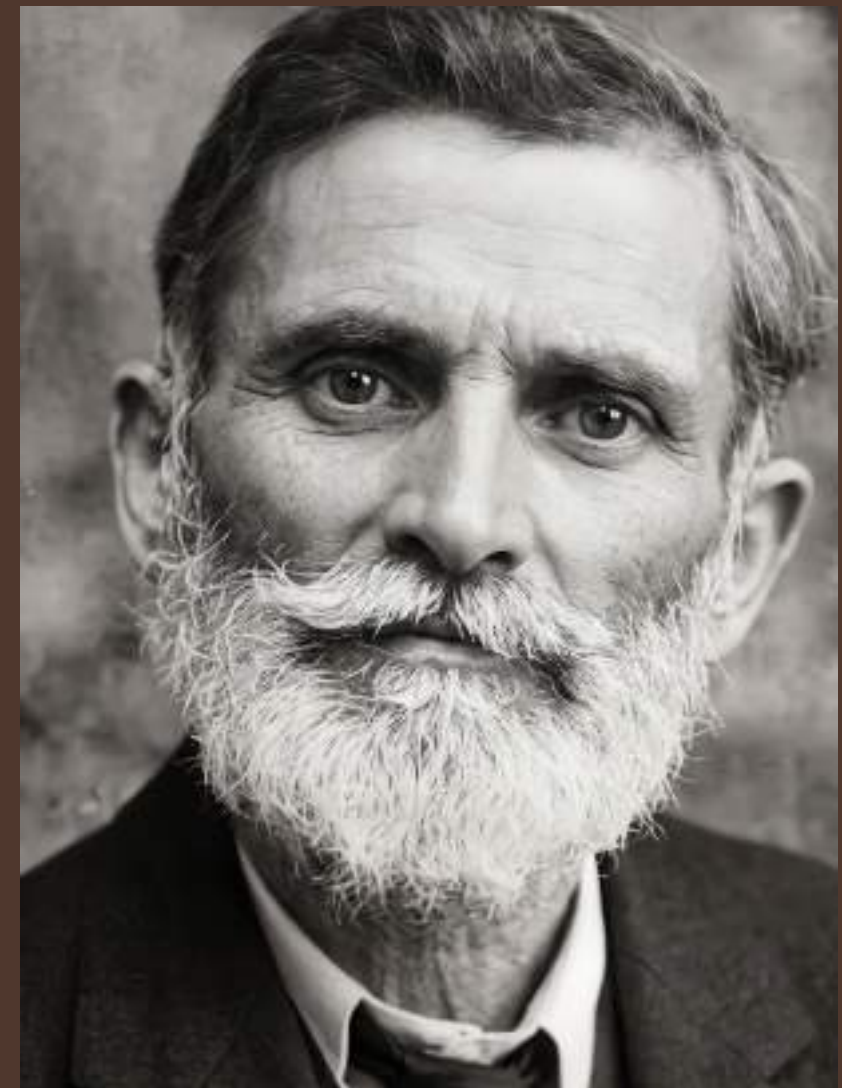
Anquetil weaponized the only asset the worker had left: the physical body. In September 1938, orchestrating a strike of 3,000 dockers, he brought the machinery of Port-Louis to an absolute standstill. The colonial government, perceiving him as the brain of the paralysis, exiled him to the isolated basalt of Rodrigues.

**But exiling the flesh could
not exile the idea.**

His struggle reached its tragic climax in 1943 at Belle Vue Harel, where police fired upon striking workers, claiming the life of the pregnant martyr Anjalay Coopan. This shed blood solidified the foundation of the modern Mauritian worker, eventually securing the 8-hour workday.

Anquetil’s legacy was the Fist; the physical chassis upon which the island’s dignity was built.

‘Travailleurs,



debout !’

Jack Bizall & the Organized Roar

The Context: The Hooper Commission era (1937–1938) Zone Franche, the 1975 Student Strikes and the August 1979 General Strike

The Weapon: The Organized Intellect.



If Anquetil taught the Mauritian worker how to form a fist, **Jack Bizall** (1946–) taught them the geometry of leverage. By the 1970s, the initial euphoria of Independence had settled into the concrete reality of economic anxiety. The battleground shifted from the muddy fields to the assembly lines of the newly minted textile factories and the asphalt of bus depots. The struggle required a new vocabulary.

Anger, devoid of method, is merely noise.

As a teacher and unionist, he embodied Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' and wanted to erase the boundary between the docker and the academic. Under his influence, the strike ceased to be a mere cessation of labor; it became a coordinated argument, supported by philosophers, journalists, and engaged musicians.

He diagnosed the Mauritian education system as 'intellectual Fordism', an assembly line engineered to output obedient citizens. This structural tension shattered on **May 20, 1975** when youth flooded Port-Louis demanding educational equity, met by police batons. The resulting friction forced the establishment of free secondary education.

When the historic **August 1979** strike paralyzed the island once again, it was clear the worker had learned the power of the structural chokehold. Operating through his FRAP method (Facts, Relations, Analysis, Proposals), Bizall transitioned the fight from physical survival to constitutional reform.

He took the raw anger of the fields and made it articulate.

Lindsey Collen & the Intersectional Pen

The Context: The Modern Republic, Women's Rights, Linguistic Recognition.

The Weapon: The Mind.

Today, the battle lines are quieter, but no less dangerous. You do not always need to burn a cane field or barricade a port to dismantle a system; sometimes, you simply need to tell a story.

When **Lindsey Collen** arrived from apartheid-era South Africa in 1974, the Mauritian struggle was largely being fought in textile factories and on the streets. Through her grassroots work with LALIT and the Muvman Liberasyon Fam (MLF), Collen revealed that the Mauritian worker was fighting more than just the factory boss. The new, invisible walls were the conservative patriarchy, the lingering shame around the Creole language, and outdated colonial laws.

In 1993, her book **'The Rape of Sita'** held such an uncomfortable mirror up to gender violence that the State banned it within 72 hours under the guise of blasphemy, thus proving that

A novel could hit as hard as a strike

Collen and the MLF recognized a profound truth deeply embedded in the island's history: where the past had fractured traditional structures, it was the mothers who emerged as the steadfast anchors, building and holding their families together single-handedly. Rooted in this understanding, they advocated for a reality that truly mirrored the lived experience of the Mauritian people. Their unwavering dedication catalyzed a landmark shift in perspective, ultimately ensuring the State recognized this truth by granting social housing to single women.

Whether she was fighting to elevate Mauritian Creole to a recognized language of intellect, or helping to overturn an 1838 colonial ban on abortion, Collen moved the revolution into the intimate spaces of the body and the mind.

The physical fist of the past had gracefully, but firmly, uncurled to pick up the pen.

“the same thing”

- Sita on colonisation and rape, 'the Rape of Sita', 1993



The Never Ending Draft

To observe the Mauritian identity is to accept a people eternally in motion. Emmanuel Anquetil pulled dignity from the dust of the cane fields, providing the physical architecture to stand. Jack Bizlall echoed that worth across the concrete city, supplying the structural words to be heard. Lindsey Collen turned the gaze inward, offering the intellectual scalpel to reclaim the flesh and the mind.

Together, they reveal the island's most defining, unspoken trait: an inherent drive to continuously evolve. The Mauritian identity is not a static, finished postcard. It is a living manuscript, shaped by the weight of history, yet illuminated by a quiet, unyielding momentum. The raw trials of the past have not vanished; they have simply matured, becoming the steady pulse that animates the island today. The landscape of challenges will continue to shift, but as long as this basalt rock breathes, the ink of its enduring spirit will never dry.

We have listened to the politicians and heard the activists. But a nation is also built in silence. As we close this chapter on the architects of the Mauritian myth, we turn to the ultimate witnesses: the stones. Here is an exploration of three spaces defined by the profound tension between the emptiness of the present and the overwhelming fullness of the past.



The Aapravasi Ghat.

A small courtyard of old volcanic stones, the remnants of an 1849 immigration depot, and a flight of sixteen stone steps rising from the water's edge. It remains almost forgotten amid the traffic of the capital.

Yet, between 1834 and 1920, over 450,000 indentured laborers from India walked up these stairs after surviving the crossing of the Kala Pani. It is a waiting room holding the breath of half a million ancestors.



Le Morne.

It is a monolith of basalt rising from the lagoon, a masterpiece of geological silence, standing still and empty.

But Le Morne is the most crowded empty space on the island. It is saturated with ghosts of the 'Maroons' from the eras of slavery. Beware of the silence you hear today as it is the echo of people who had to hold their breath to survive.



Marie Reine de la Paix.

Sitting on the flank of Signal Mountain. The white marble statue looks down on Port-Louis in perpetual, quiet prayer.

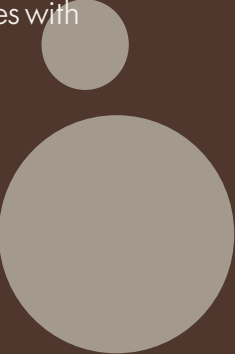
But this empty stage once gathered 100,000 people of all faiths to hear Pope John Paul II and Pope Francis. Yet, the echo of this monument is also political, having seen the streets of Port-Louis screams during riots of 1968, 1975 and 1999. A beautiful paradox; perfect peace anchoring a restless island.



We have spent these pages dissecting the architects of the Mauritian myth. We have sat at the mahogany table with the politicians who drew our borders, and we have marched alongside the unionists who demanded our dignity. But as the wind sweeps over the basalt of Le Morne, as the dark waters lap against the Aapravasi Ghat, and as the sun sets over the terraces of Marie Reine de la Paix, a final, humbling truth emerges.

The true architects of our identity are not just the statues in the squares or the names printed in official textbooks. They are the unnamed runaways who chose the void of the cliff over the whip. They are the frightened laborers who carried the weight of an empire up sixteen stone steps. They are the silent, hopeful masses who gather on a hill or in the streets of Port Louis.

This is the essence of the Mauritian identity. It is not a polished, single narrative. It is a complex, beautiful mosaic. We are the descendants of those who refused to break. The myth of this island is not written in ink; it is carved into the very stone, waiting for us to listen. As we close this first dossier, we leave the monuments to their silence, carrying their echoes with us into the vibrant, chaotic reality of who we are becoming.



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THE PEN IN THE WOUND

If the architects of our past built the nation with laws and concrete, the voices of An Archipelago of Tongues dismantle it with ink. We leave the official monuments behind to enter a space where history is whispered, shouted, and bled. For decades, the Mauritian literary export was a polite breeze. But a nation cannot truly know its own anatomy if it only looks at its postcard reflection. Three women grabbed the pen like a scalpel, stripping away the paradise to reveal the open wound of a pulsing, feverish island.



The Claustrophobia of the Flesh

Ananda Devi

If the Mauritian tourist brochure sells a weightless dream, Ananda Devi anchors us in a heavy, breathing reality. In masterpieces like *'Ève de ses décombres'* and *'Le Sari vert'*, Devi turns her back on the luxury resorts to wander the forgotten, cracked concrete of places like Troumaron.

For Devi, the island is not a sanctuary; it is a tightly woven web of expectations, a panopticon where the community watches and judges. She dissects the silent struggles of the female body, navigating the stifling humidity of religious traditions, systemic inequalities, and male dominance.

Her characters do not ask for pity; they are feral survivors, fighting within a geography that is quite literally too small for their ambitions.

To read Devi is to understand that the Mauritian 'harmonious melting pot' is, in reality, a daily, exhausting negotiation of space and flesh. To be Mauritian, in her prose, is to constantly push back against the boundaries designed to keep you quiet, finding a fierce, desperate beauty in the cracks of the concrete.

‘Troumaron, c’est une sorte d’entonnoir ; le dernier goulet où viennent se déverser les eaux usées de tout un pays. Ici, on recase les réfugiés des cyclones, ceux qui n’ont pas trouvé à se loger après une tempête tropicale et qui, deux ou cinq ou dix ou vingt ans après, ont toujours les orteils à l’eau.’

— Ananda Devi, *Ève de ses décombres*, 2006

The Phantom Limb

Shenaz Patel

How does an island articulate its identity when a piece of its own geography has been amputated? For decades, Shenaz Patel fiercely refused to let Mauritius forget the Chagossians, the islanders exiled in the shadows of the Cold War to make way for a military base. In *‘Le Silence des Chagos’*, Patel acted as a guardian of the unwritten archive. While politicians negotiated behind closed doors, she lent a profound literary dignity to those pushed out of the official historical frame.

History ultimately bent to this persistence. Even as recent geopolitical shifts finally acknowledged Mauritian sovereignty over the archipelago, it was the ink of writers that kept the heartbeat of the displaced people alive during the long years of erasure, holding the space until justice could arrive.

‘— Ê, kot ou pé alé ? [...] Mo lé
koné kan bato pou alé.
— Zil inn fermé.’

— Shenaz Patel, *Le silence des Chagos*, 2005

But her defiance is not merely geographical; it is fundamentally linguistic. Patel is a fierce advocate for the Mauritian Creole language, the mother tongue of the archipelago. In a society that still quietly equates French and English with intellect, she translates, writes, and elevates Creole to the status of high art.

Identity, Patel observes, cannot be forged in a borrowed language. She reveals that the Mauritian soul is built on the courage to embrace the entirety of our history and the unyielding pride to speak our truth in the exact rhythm and vocabulary of our own streets.

‘— Eh, où est-ce que vous allez ?
[...] Je voudrais savoir quand le
bateau s’en ira.
— L’île a fermé.’

— Shenaz Patel, *Le silence des Chagos*

The Archaeology of the Intimate

Nathacha Appanah

From her debut *Les Rochers de Poudre d'Or*, Nathacha Appanah honored the silent sweat of the Indian indentured laborers who crossed the ocean to rebuild the island's economy. She proved that the Mauritian identity is a complex tapestry woven by exiles who chose to take root in foreign soil rather than surrender.

Yet, with her recent masterpiece *'La nuit au cœur'*, Appanah turns her gaze inward, probing a more intimate, immediate darkness. The novel intertwines the destinies of three women running to reclaim their lives from domestic trauma.

Rather than dwelling solely on the violence, Appanah focuses on the sheer, unstoppable momentum of survival.

Through this heartbreaking narrative, Appanah suggests that resilience is the very marrow of the Mauritian identity. A true sense of self is not built on ignoring the shadows, but on the capacity to protect the vulnerable and step out of the dark. We are a people born from the ocean's crossing, who still know how to survive the night.

‘De ces nuits et de ces vies,
de ces femmes qui courent,
de ces cœurs qui luttent,
de ces instants qui sont si
accablants qu’ils ne rentrent pas
dans la mesure du temps,
il a fallu faire quelque chose.’

— Nathacha Appanah, *La nuit au cœur*, 2025

The postcard has burned away.

What remains is not a sunset over a five-star lagoon, but the resilience of Troumaron. It is the regained memory of the Chagos, whispered in the native tongue. It is the courage of women stepping out of the night.

Our literature is no longer an export; it is a reckoning.
The real, breathing Mauritius has finally found its voice.

The Sweet Mouth *aka la bouss dou*

How do you feed a nation? You invent a dish that fits in the palm of a hand, costs almost nothing, and contains the entire history of the island.

COMPONENT A: The Golden Canvas - The Flatbread

The Recipe: 500g plain flour, 250g yellow split peas (dholl chana), a pinch of turmeric, roasted ground cumin, salt, water, and oil. Dough balls are rolled flat before being flash-cooked on a hot tawa.

The Origin: Imported from Bihar, India, arriving in 1834 with the first indentured laborers.

COMPONENT C: The Earthy Core - Cari Gros Pois

The Recipe: Butter beans (gros pois) pressure-cooked until creamy, then simmered in a mild, fragrant Mauritian curry powder (masala).

The Anchor: If the flatbread is the envelope and the rougaille is the spark, the gros pois is the comforting, creamy anchor that makes the meal deeply satisfying.

COMPONENT E: The Democratic Wrapper - The Paper

The Material: Traditionally, yesterday's newspaper. Today, a brown paper bag.

The Equalizer: The Dhall Puri is street food, a symbol of Mauritian democracy. Whether you are a government minister in a tailored suit or a mason covered in cement dust, you eat it standing up, on the sidewalk, holding the exact same paper wrapper, paying the exact same price.

COMPONENT B: The Red Acid - The Rougaille

The Recipe: Crushed local tomatoes (pommes d'amour), onions, garlic, ginger, fresh thyme, and coriander, simmered down to a thick, rich sauce.

The Influence: A direct Mediterranean and European influence. The acidity of the pomme d'amour is chemically necessary here: it cuts through the heavy starch of the flatbread and balances the spices perfectly.

COMPONENT D: The Heat Sensor - Piment Écrasé

The Recipe: Crushed green chilies, a touch of vinegar or lemon, garlic, and salt.

The Customizer: The interactive element.

Added strictly according to the consumer's tolerance. It is the electric shock that awakens the palate.

How to eat a dholl puri :

1. Hold flat in one hand.
2. Smear with rougaille and butter beans.
3. Add chili (with caution).
4. Roll into a tight cylinder.
5. Eat immediately on the street corner. Beware of the hot curry dripping from the bottom.



The Battle For The Tongue

A language born in the shadows of the cane fields, banned in schools, mocked in high society, and dismissed as a mere 'patois'. Today, it is the true marrow of the island, the one unifying rhythm that tells us who we are the moment it leaves our lips. The journey of Mauritian Creole (Morisyen) is not just a linguistic evolution; it is the anatomy of a people taking ownership of their own narrative.

How does a symbolic language travel from the verses of William Shakespeare to the glowing screens of generation Z?

To understand the Mauritian identity, one must understand its deepest linguistic trauma. For generations, the children of Mauritius were taught that their mother tongue was illegitimate. French for prestige, English for power, and Creole for the street as the vocabulary was deemed unfit for complex thought.

Enter Dev Virahsawmy (1942–2023) who refused this stratification. He did not simply defend the language, he proved that *Morisyen* was a fully-fledged, sophisticated language. How? He subjected it to the ultimate literary stress test by translating William Shakespeare.

Virahsawmy translated several masterpieces, but none was more symbolic than his 1991 translation of 'The Tempest', which he renamed **Toufann**. The choice was not accidental. The Tempest is a story of a colonized island, of a magical master (Prospero), and an enslaved native (Caliban).

In Toufann, Caliban's colonial curse is inverted. By dressing Prospero and Caliban in the rhythmic syntax of the Indian Ocean, Virahsawmy stripped away the colonial weight of the English language. He proved that the 'patois' could carry the weight of existential philosophy, power, and magic.

Virahsawmy was the alchemist who turned a dialect of survival into a classical instrument.

PROSPERO: — Twa ki twa pou donn mwa konsey. To koze kan dimann twa koze.

KALIBANN, koz dousman: — Tonn montre mwa kozé; sel seki mo'nn gagne ladan se ki aster mo konn zouré.

PROSPERO: — Pa bliye dan ki latrap mo ti tir twa. Twa ek to mama zot ti pe mordefen ler mo ti vinn isi ... Pa bliye serman ki to mama ti fer. To pou travay ar mwa, pou mwa, obeyir mwa osi lontan ki mwa mo'le. Rayt!

KALIBANN: — Wi, Misie.



If Virahsawmy secured the literary soul of the language, the digital era confirmed its undeniable daily pulse. Fast forward to the 2020s. The battleground is no longer the theater stage; it is the glowing screen.

Look at any WhatsApp group, TikTok comment section, or Facebook feed in Mauritius. The rigid parameters of colonial grammar dissolve into Kreol 2.0. It is a frantic, abbreviated, and constantly mutating code.

«Ki position?» becomes «Kipz.»

Words are mashed together, emojis replace punctuation, and English or French slang is seamlessly woven into Creole sentences in a brilliant display of constant code-switching. To the traditional grammarian, it is chaos. To the observer, it is a vibrantly living organism.

What makes this digital revolution so profound for the Mauritian identity? It is the ultimate equalizer. A generation types its grief, its humor, and its mundane reality using the exact same phonetic slang, regardless of ancestry.

Virahsawmy wanted to prove that Creole could carry the weight of Shakespearean tragedy. Generation Z has proven that it can carry the weight of modern, unfiltered Mauritian life.

PROSPERO: — Kalibann, mo bien apresie vites to apran. Zordi se twa ki fer tou meinntenens, tou reparasion. Parfwa to mem amenn bann ameliorasion. Mem si parfwa mo enpe brit ar twa, mo bien apresie to travay. Kan mo travay fini net, mo pou donn twa to liberte. To kontan? ... Reponn mwa.

...

KALIBANN: — Liberte?

PROSPERO: — Wi. Liberte.

...

KALIBANN: — Zame ou'nn anpes mwa fer kiksoz.

PROSPERO: — Parski to'nn touzour anvi fer seki mwa mo anvi to fer.

Aujourd'hui

Ayo mari nissa sa film la 🔥

9:15 AM ✓✓

Serye? Mo ti krwar mari foupamal sa.

9:17 AM

Non ta, to bizin get sa.

9:18 AM ✓✓

Vinn pran mwa demin nou al gete?

9:20 AM

Plan la korek bro.

9:22 AM ✓✓

From the solemn stages of high literature to the rapid-fire jokes of a group chat, the journey of the Mauritian Creole is the ultimate story of a nation reclaiming its voice. We no longer need to borrow the words of others to describe our reality, we are finally speaking for ourselves.

Sirandanes & Diktons

Before the ink, there was the voice. The Mauritian worldview is not hidden in philosophical treatises; it is condensed into sharp, visceral metaphors passed down through generations. These diktons and sirandanes are the island's rawest poetry born from observations of human nature forged in the fields, the kitchens, and the sea.

Here, the tongue does not debate; it strikes.

Lalang pena lezo
Whoever gossips to you, will gossip about you.

Kras anler tom lor nene

What goes around comes around, you reap what you sow.

**Kan montagn pran dife, tou dimoun kone; kan
leker pran dife, kisann-la kone ?**

Great grief is silent.

Apré lamor, latizann

Locking the stable door after the horse has bolted.

Dilo dormi touy dimounn

Silent people are the one we should fear as we don't really know them.

Kan lipie glise, lekkor swiv

*If the foundation is weak, the house will not stand,
A house built on sand cannot stand.*

Al lasas perdi plas

You snooze, you loose - the absent are always in the wrong.

Bef lager dan disab, sakenn get so lizie

When problems arrive, each has to manage on one's own.

The Island's Vocal Cord

It is the oldest dialect of the island. Séga is not, and has never been, just «holiday music.» It is a rhythm born in chains, forged in the absolute dark, and electrified by freedom. To understand the Mauritian soul, one must listen to the genealogy of a rhythm, told through the shamans who played it and the instruments that carried it. It is the story of how resilient people took the burning embers of the slave camps and beat their bare hands against them until they sparked the electrical currents that now shake the world.

Before it was played in the glowing lobbies of five-star hotels to welcome tourists, the séga was a clandestine ritual of the night. It belonged to the lakour. It was the music of the descendants of slaves and a profound, visceral response to exhaustion and grief.

No one embodies this raw melancholy of the working class better than Alphonse Ravaton, immortalized as **Ti-Frère** (1900–1992).

With a voice that sounded like crushed gravel and old rum, Ti-Frère sang the Séga Tipik during the clandestine Saturday night gatherings, to light the spark his village needed. He did not merely 'lift the atmosphere' of a dull evening; he orchestrated a collective release. He turned the late hours of the nights into profound rituals of endurance, ensuring that his people could dance through the heavy weight of their own existence.

Through his tracks he represents the embers of the Mauritian identity: the profound realization that rhythm is the ultimate survival mechanism.

Ti-Frère left behind an incalculable inheritance. He proved that the truest Mauritian stories are not written in history books; they are cried out around a fire.



INSTRUMENT 01: THE RAVANNE



The absolute foundation of the Séga Tipik. It is a living organism composed of a wide circular wooden frame covered with stretched, dried goat skin. Before it can be played, it must be 'awakened'. The musician holds the drum over the flames of a campfire, using the heat to tighten the hide and raise its pitch to a deep, resonant boom. It represents the earth, but requires fire to speak.



By the early 1990s, the embers of the lakour had been doused in gasoline. The island was industrializing rapidly, and its heartbeat demanded amplification. The Ségas were no longer confined to the shadows of the filao trees; it plugged into the national grid.

Enter **Cassiya**. Named in homage to their working-class neighborhood of Cassis in Port-Louis, this band did not just play music; they orchestrated a cultural earthquake. They took the sacred, uneven pulse of the ravanne and armed it with heavy electric basslines, blazing brass sections, and undeniable hooks. At the center of this hurricane was the voice of **Désiré François** backed by the sheer, unadulterated voltage of a modern orchestra.

When Cassiya sang anthems like *'Séparation'* or *'Rev Nou Zanse'*, they transformed the Mauritian identity. The pain of the past was still woven into the lyrics, but the rhythm had become triumphant. When they sold out the legendary Zénith in Paris, thousands of miles from the Indian Ocean, they didn't just play a concert; they proved that the rhythm of survival had mutated into the ultimate badge of national pride.

INSTRUMENT 02: THE ELECTRIC BASS

In the traditional acoustic Ségas, the low, thumping frequencies were provided by the tambour makadam or the deepest strikes of the ravanne. The electric bass replaced this, locking in with the drum kit to create a driving, relentless groove that physically vibrates the chest of the listener. It is the current that allowed the Ségas to drown out the noise of the city and reach the masses.

Every musical revolution eventually reaches a point of saturation. By the 2000s, commercial Ségga had become hyper-synthesized, fast, and often stripped of its initial depth. To save the soul of the music, one man had to unplug it.

Stéphane Osman, known as **Menwar**, is the alchemist of the Mauritian rhythm. Recognizing that heavy electronics were burying the intricate subtleties of the Ségga, he initiated a radical return to the roots while deconstructing the traditional Ségga Tipik. How?

He pioneered new, complex striking techniques on the ravanne and infused the Mauritian pulse with the undeniable melancholy of African blues and Malagasy salegy.

With monumental albums like '*Ay Ay Lolo*', Menwar conducted a laboratory of identity. He elevated the Mauritian rhythm to the prestigious stages of international World Music festivals, not as exotic entertainment, but as high art.

He closed the circle, stripping away all artificial noise to return the ancestral fire to its most fragile, unadorned state thus proving that the island's voice only needs the undeniable truth of bare hands hitting dried animal skin.



INSTRUMENT 03:

THE MARAVANNE & THE TRYANG



The masters of polyrhythm. The Maravanne (a flat box filled with dried canna seeds) is shaken from side to side, creating a continuous, sweeping sound reminiscent of ocean waves crashing on the shore. The Tryang (a thick iron rod) cuts straight through this fluid wall of sound with sharp, metallic, syncopated strikes. Together with the Ravanne, they form the Holy Trinity of Mauritian rhythm.



How does a rhythm become a riot? If Ti-Frère laid the acoustic foundations of the Mauritian sorrow in the hidden courtyards, the late 1990s required a new vocabulary to articulate the realities of the urban ghettos.

*On **February 16, 1999**, a musician stepped onto a stage in Rose-Hill holding a guitar and a joint. Five days later, he was dead in a police cell, and Mauritius was literally in flames. This is not a biography. This is the minute-by-minute anatomy of a cultural explosion. How Joseph Réginald Topize, known as **Kaya**, forged a spiritual dialect out of systemic neglect? How a single concert forced the island to listen to a voice it had long chosen to ignore?*

The Syntax Of a Riot

To understand the gravity in the air on that Tuesday afternoon in February 1999, one must examine the man the crowd was waiting for. Kaya did not merely play music; he engineered a new sociological language for the island's Creole underclass.

Observing that traditional Ségga was increasingly sanitized for hotel lobbies and national broadcasts, Kaya, born in the impoverished suburb of Roche-Bois, sought a heavier resonance. He fused the ternary pulse of his ancestors with the spiritual, off-beat bass of Jamaican Reggae. He called this new hybrid **Seggae**.

Seggae served as a true mirror to the Mauritian reality. In songs like '*Simé Lalimier*' and '*Chante l'Amour*', Kaya channeled this unique rhythm to weave a message of peace, while shedding light on unspoken societal divides and the enduring struggles of everyday life. For the Zilwa (the islanders), he was a pillar of their shared identity.

On February 16, 1999, this voice was scheduled to be heard at Place Edward VII in Rose-Hill. The political party Mouvement Républicain, led by lawyer Rama Valayden, had organized a free public rally advocating for the decriminalization of marijuana. For Kaya, cannabis was a spiritual sacrament. Believing the political nature of the rally offered a protective context, he agreed to perform. It was a miscalculation of the boundaries separating political rhetoric from state law.

FEBRUARY 16, 1999: MINUTE BY MINUTE

[17:30] THE ARRIVAL

Place Edward VII swells with over 2,000 attendees. The air is dense with patchouli and openly smoked cannabis. The police are present, but they are keeping their distance. It is a political rally; intervening in a crowd this dense, fueled by political rhetoric and reggae, would be tactical suicide.

[18:45] THE POLITICAL SHIELD

Political figures take the microphone, framing the decriminalization of soft drugs as a human rights issue. This rhetoric creates a fragile illusion of legal immunity among the attendees. The stage is set as a space of free expression, blurring the lines of consequence.

[19:15] THE RHYTHM BEGINS

Kaya and his band, Racine Tatane, step into the lights. The roar from the crowd is deafening. Known to be deeply introverted off-stage, Kaya assumes a magnetic presence behind the microphone. The syncopated basslines of Seggae begin to vibrate against the concrete architecture of Rose-Hill.

[19:42] THE SACRAMENT

They are playing *'Mo la Misère'*. The groove is deep. Kaya steps to the microphone. According to multiple witnesses and later police reports, it is in these moments that Kaya publicly lights a joint on stage. He smokes it openly and passes it to his bandmates. It is executed not as an act of violent defiance, but as a spiritual gesture perfectly aligned with the rally's theme. Yet, regardless of intent, it constitutes a direct violation of Mauritian law in plain sight of the authorities.

[20:30] THE DESCENT

The concert ends peacefully. The crowd disperses peacefully into the humid Mauritian night, high on the music and the unprecedented sense of freedom. Kaya packs his guitar and goes home to his wife, Véronique, and his children.

[FEBRUARY 18 - 06:00 AM] THE ARREST

Two days later, the illusion of immunity shatters. The police raid Kaya's home. He is arrested solely for the consumption of cannabis on stage. Unable to immediately produce the staggering bail amount of 10,000 Rupees, the musician is remanded to the 'Alcatraz' holding cells at the Line Barracks in Port-Louis.



On **Sunday, February 21, 1999**, the frequency of the island snapped. Kaya was found dead in his cell. The authorities claimed the musician had suffered a withdrawal crisis, fracturing his own skull. This narrative was immediately rejected. An independent autopsy revealed injuries that strongly pointed toward police brutality.

His death was the catalyst for a profound societal rupture. If Seggae was the defining language of the Creole underclass, Kaya's death in state custody was translated as the ultimate confirmation of their disposability.

Within hours, Roche-Bois erupted, and the anger rapidly decentralized across the island. For four days, the infrastructure of the Republic was paralyzed by burning barricades, besieged stations, and the flaring of dormant communal tensions.

The myth of the perfectly harmonious 'Rainbow Nation' was critically fractured.

Kaya's final days forced Mauritius to gaze into its most uncomfortable mirror. Before 1999, Seggae was often dismissed by the elite as the noise of the margins.

Today, it became a scar on the national conscience, like a sacred hymn, and stands as an indelible dialect within the Mauritian identity. One cannot hear the heavy off-beat of Seggae without hearing the echo of the riots. He plugged the acoustic sorrow of the island into the electric grid of the 90s, leaving behind a complex legacy: a martyr to the streets, a cautionary tale to the state, and a rhythm that forever changed the Republic.

The concert in Rose-Hill only
lasted two hours, but its final
chord is still ringing.

The Taste After Dawn

When the smoke of a historical fracture clears, the island does not stop spinning. It simply wakes up the next day, boils water, and goes to work. Released in 2015, Désiré François's 'Ti dipain griyé' observe a quiet Mauritian reality; not every dialect is born of political tension or intellectual debate. Some of the most defining language of the island is spoken in the silent, repetitive, and deeply human rituals.

At its core, 'Ti dipain griyé' is a sonic portrait of resilience wrapped in romance at dawn. It depicts the struggle to 'rod lavi' (earn a living).

Rejecting grand gestures, the song also proves that true wealth lies in simplicity like laying down your tools to surrender to the cyclone and embrace a 'grass mat'. Ultimately, the island's true essence isn't found in luxury resorts, but beneath a humming tin roof, anchored by a love as warm and essential as a piece of buttered toast.

Ti dipain griyé fonn dïber
Ti dité so rann vaper
Anba la varang mo apé get lapli tonbé
Mélina pé ranpli mo katora,
Déor lapli dir mwa ki la,
Mo pé pran kouraz pou mo al rod sa lavi-la

Dan ti lakaz tol ou koné,
Kan lapli-la pé tombé
Mo senti frison là lévé
Enn ti ler lamour ki pasé

Mélina ti pé alé vini
Li ti ankor dan so ti rob dé nwi,
Mo zoli ti fam,
Finn dérout mo lespri
Mélina get déor kouma lapli pé tombé,
Sa létan-la pa pou kapav krépi,
Mo ramas zouti azordi

Mélina get déor apré Mélina répliké
Sé enn kozé pa kozé,
Pa bizin dir mwa monn koné

Ti dipain griyé fonn dïber
Ti dité so rann vapér
Anba la varang mo apé get lapli tonbé

Pa bizin mo amenn ou lor montayn
Pou get zako fer grimass
Dan ti lakaz tole gété kouma nou ti kokass

Mélina kontan sinsérité
Mwa mo kontan sinplisité
Nou ti éna bel konplisité
Dan tempét nou ti rézisté

Pa bizin Mélina met mini
pou li fer mo nam anvi li
Dan letan liver li resof mo lavi

Mélina get déor kouma lapli pé tonbé,
Sa létan-la pa pou kapav krépi,
Mo ramas zouti azordi

Mélina get déor apré Mélina répliké
Sé enn kozé pa kozé,
Pa bizin dir mwa monn koné

O la é, la li lé,
Enn ti freser pé baté,
Enn ti gaté gras matiné
Dan ti lakaz tol glasé

The Concrete Vocabulary

When the Walls Learn to Speak

A language is not always spoken; sometimes, it is sprayed. Sometimes, the most immediate and uncensored dialect does not exist in dictionaries or on theater stages. It lives on the blistering concrete of Port-Louis, the fading walls of Rose-Hill, and the sun-bleached facades of the coastal villages.

Mauritian street art is the visual continuation of the island's identity, never static but rather a living canvas. It is a loud, unapologetic collision of ancestral memory and global pop culture. These collages are not mere decorations; they are public transcripts.



Fig 2. — Port-Louis, 2023.



Fig 1. — Ville Noire, 2012.



Fig 3. — Port-Louis, 2015.



Fig 4. — Venpin Street, 2010's.



Fig 5 — Port-Louis, 2010's.



Fig 6. — Chinatown, 2010's.



Fig 7. — Chinatown, 2010's.



Fig 8. — Tamarin, 2023.



Fig 10. — Port-Louis, 2023.



Fig 9. — Royal Road, 2016.



Fig 11. — Caudan Arts Centre, 2022.



History is not solely written by the pens of historians; it is spoken in the shadows. In this archipelago of tongues, we have mapped the unedited Mauritian identity: the classical gravity of a reclaimed Creole, the electric grief of a Seggae riot, the aerosol syntax of our walls, and the quiet, charred taste of the dawn. This, too, is the Mauritian truth; a living, breathing vocabulary of survival.

Yet, as the echoes of these diverse dialects settle into silence, a fundamental realization emerges. A tongue cannot speak without breath, and a ravanne cannot resonate without the strike of a calloused hand. The voice is merely a passenger; the body is the vessel.

To fully grasp the anatomy of the island, we must now turn our gaze from the sounds that fill the air to the physical forms that anchor them to the earth. We step out of the chorus and into the theater of the flesh to examine the dirty hands that built the concrete, the heavy objects of daily labor, and the shifting posture of a nation in motion.

Where the echo fades, the body begins.



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The Breath Of Maryse

The Anatomy of a Run

There are records broken by science, and there are records forged by pure, unadulterated determination. For 34 years, the Mauritian national marathon record belonged to a woman who possessed none of the modern armors of athletics, solely on the intrinsic mechanics of her own frame.

*To observe Maryse Justin who ran **42.195 kilometers** of South Korean asphalt in **2 hours, 48 minutes, and 40 seconds** in **1988** is to observe the Mauritian working body in its most concentrated resilient state. It is an exploration of physical ownership: a body built to absorb the violence of the asphalt, to breathe, and sustain its own momentum.*



To run a marathon is to engage in a quiet, methodical destruction of one's own body. The mechanics of the body operate in harmony; the heart is pumping efficiently; the lungs are expanding with a steady, metronomic rhythm.

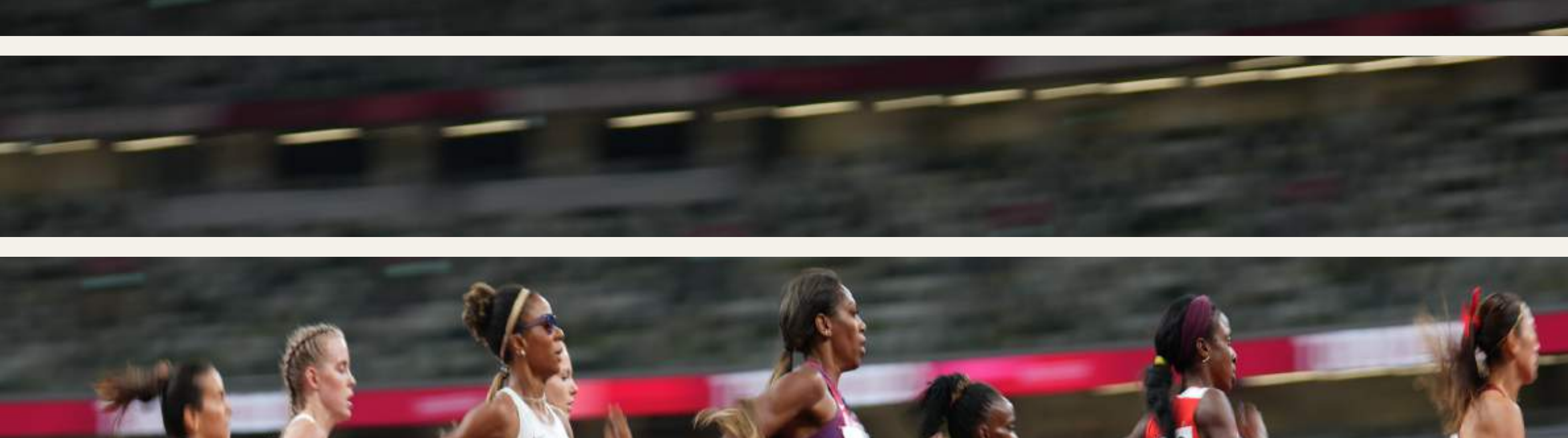
But for Maryse Justin, the run is a solitary equation between flesh and pavement.

She is not surrounded by an armada of physiologists or biomechanical engineers. She is a woman from Mauritius, carrying the weight of a developing island on her shoulders, running against athletes backed by geopolitical superpowers.

Every time her thin-soled shoe strikes the South Korean pavement, her skeletal structure absorbs an impact force equivalent to three times her body weight. The vibration travels straight up the shin bone, into the knees, and up to the spine.

To endure this is not a matter of talent; it is a matter of profound, silent endurance. It mirrors a specific trait of the Mauritian DNA of that era: the quiet capacity to absorb physical repetition and seamlessly translate it into continuous forward motion.

1988, Seoul Olympics - KM 10



1988, Seoul Olympics - KM 30

In sports physiology, it is simply called 'the Wall'. It occurs when the human liver entirely depletes its reserves of glycogen. The body desperately searches for fuel and calculates how to continue moving. The brain sends emergency signals to the legs: *Stop*.

It is in this precise physiological valley, that Maryse Justin transcends the sport. When the body has nothing left to burn, what keeps a runner moving? You do not run with your legs anymore; you run with your gut. You run with your memory.

In 1988, the physical form of a Mauritian working-class woman was a utilized entity shaped by the *Zone Franche* factories and domestic life. Maryse's stride in these kilometers stands as a profound departure from this reality.

The marathon offers a rare space of physical autonomy. Her body operates for itself; her breath, her muscle fatigue, and her pacing belong exclusively to her. It is the Mauritian body stepping out of its utilitarian role to engage in a grueling, and perfectly calibrated dialogue with its own limits.



1988, Seoul Olympics - KM 42.195

She crosses the line. The clock stops at
2:48:40.

For thirty-four years, this sequence of numbers stood as an untouchable monolith in Mauritian sports history. Generations of runners tried to break it, armed with better shoes, better diets, and better tracks. It wasn't until 2022 that **Katie Mauthoor** finally lowered the mark, bringing a modern closure to a decades-long chase.

Maryse Justin's 1988 run remains an indelible blueprint of the Mauritian anatomy. She proved that before the era of engineered footwear, the island's identity can be propelled forward by the sheer, unassisted momentum of the human frame.

She left her breath out there on the asphalt, and for over three decades, the entire island ran in her slipstream, showing that the ultimate architecture of endurance is the body itself.

THE MUSCLE AND THE METRIC

The Anatomy of an Era: 1988 (Maryse Justin)
VS 2022 (Katie Mauthoor)

The Shock Absorber

- **1988:** Thin 'EVA' foam soles. The body absorbs nearly the entirety of the shock. The calf muscles and Achilles tendons bear the full mechanical load over the kilometers, demanding absolute structural resilience from the runner.
- **Today:** 'Super Shoes' embedded with rigid carbon-fiber plates and ultra-responsive aerospace foam. The shoe acts as a kinetic spring, returning up to 85% of the energy back into the runner's stride and drastically altering the biomechanics of fatigue.

The Chemistry

- **1988:** Water grabbed from paper cups; a lump of sugar or a wet sponge. The metabolism is largely left to fend for itself, navigating severe blood-sugar fluctuations through intrinsic conditioning.
- **Today:** Hydro-gels synthesized in laboratories, containing an exact ratio of maltodextrin and fructose. Consumed with precision every 20 minutes to completely bypass digestion and directly feed the muscles.

The Isolation

- **1988:** A basic stopwatch. Pacing was gauged entirely through the physical perception of breathing and muscle tension. The runner operated in a state of total psychological and physiological isolation.
- **Today:** GPS watches providing real-time heart rate, running cadence turning the solitary runner into the protected engine.

The Artifacts of Effort

Maryse Justin demonstrated the profound autonomy of the body in motion, relying solely on the architecture of breath and bone. Yet, the daily history of Mauritian labor is rarely an unassisted endeavor; it is defined by the constant friction between the human frame and the material world. Still today, tools acts as the silent extensions of our anatomy. These objects are not merely artifacts of labor, they are the tactile archives that shaped the hands of a nation.



Visual 1: The Measure of Endurance

Before the era of GPS trackers and digital metrics, physiological limits were calculated by the ticking of coiled springs. Held in the palm at the edge of a cinder track, this mechanical instrument captured the exact moment the Mauritian body pushed past its perceived threshold. It is the artifact of a solitary, unassisted dialogue with time, the strict measure of an island in motion.

THE ANALOG STOPWATCH

Visual 2: The Fibrous Architecture

Made of coastal pandanus leaves, it was the primary container of the Mauritian household. It provides immense tensile strength without rigid mass, acting as a direct extension of the arm. Calibrated to carry heavy yields of raw vegetables from *la foire* (local market), it remains an artifact from an era where the exact weight of a family's sustenance was supported entirely by the physical friction of the grip.



THE TENTE VACOAS



Visual 3: The Cast-Iron Metronome

Before the digital era, the Mauritian body aligned itself with the factory floor. The sewing machine was not just an apparatus; it was the mechanical metronome of the Zone Franche. This cast-iron pedal, polished by repetitive strikes, dictated the rhythm of an entire generation's economic shift. It remains the physical artifact of a meticulous, continuous kinetic output.

THE SINGER

Dirty Hands



THE KINETIC IMPACT (Rajan, Sugarcane Cutter)

The traditional laborer strikes the earth. His body is entirely submitted to the geometry of the fields and the harshness of the soil. It is a trade defined by repetitive, ballistic motion and continuous dermal friction.

- **04:30 AM** | The fields are still dark. Rajan (58) steps into the sharp, dense rows of sugarcane that were burned the night before. The air is thick with ash. Before the sun even rises, his hands and forearms are coated in a layer of black soot that settles deep into the lines of his skin.
- **08:00 AM** | The physical toll peaks. Harvesting cane is not a continuous pull, but a violent, repetitive impact. Rajan swings the machete hundreds of times an hour. The shockwave travels from the steel blade, through the calloused palm, directly into the elbow and shoulder joints. The body acts as a blunt force instrument.
- **02:00 PM** | The quota is met by weight. Rajan's hands are stiff, his knuckles swollen from the micro-traumas of the impacts. The dirt on his skin is a literal map of the island's primary historical export. His body is exhausted, but it has shaped the landscape.

Clean Hands



THE PRECISION GRIP (Yann, Hydroponic Agronomist)

The modern agricultural worker relies on chemistry. The physical risk is mitigated by controlled environments. The body is still deeply engaged, but it functions as a highly sensitive, data-gathering tool.

- **06:00 AM** | Yann (28) arrives at the climate-controlled greenhouse in the Smart City precinct. He does not check the sky for rain; he checks his tablet for humidity algorithms. His environment is sterile, devoid of volcanic dust or sharp leaves.
- **10:00 AM** | The work requires standing and moving, but the friction is gone. Yann uses his fingertips to delicately adjust the irrigation tubes feeding the lettuce crops. He measures the pH and electrical conductivity of the water using digital sensors. His grip requires extreme fine motor skills rather than kinetic force.
- **03:00 PM** | Yann completes his shift. He has produced as much caloric value as a traditional field, but without ever touching soil. His hands are completely clean. He washes them out of protocol, not necessity.

Dirty Hands



THE WEIGHT (Clifford, Traditional Mason)

The Mauritian infrastructure of the late 20th century was built on the absolute structural endurance of its workforce. To build a house was to physically transfer the weight of the materials through the human spine.

07:00 AM | Clifford (45) stands in the damp morning air, holding a heavy shovel. Before ready-mix trucks became standard, concrete was mixed on the ground. The physical resistance of wet sand, gravel, and cement requires explosive core strength. The alkaline dust from the cement dries his hands, creating deep, painful fissures in the skin.

11:00 AM | It is the hour of the 'dallé' (roof casting). A human chain is formed. Clifford manually lifts heavy tin buckets of wet concrete over his head, passing them up the scaffolding. His deltoids burn. His body is the elevator, the crane, and the engine.

05:00 PM | The roof is cast. Clifford's hands are raw and chemically burned by the lime. The physical architecture of the island stands entirely upon the silent degradation of his cartilage.

Clean Hands



THE VECTOR (Saraswati, BIM Coordinator & Drone Pilot)

The modern builder does not lift the structure; she maps it. The Mauritian building site requires a new physical posture: one of observation, spatial awareness, and digital manipulation.

08:00 AM | Saraswati (29) arrives on the site of a new commercial development. She is wearing a hard hat and steel-toed boots, but her primary tool weighs less than a kilogram. She powers up the surveying drone.

01:00 PM | Standing at the edge of the foundation, Saraswati's thumbs execute microscopic movements on the remote's joysticks. She is flying the drone to create a 3D topographical map of the site. Her physical exertion is minimal, but the cognitive load is immense. Her eyes constantly shift between the physical drone in the sky and the telemetry data on her screen.

04:00 PM | The survey is complete. Saraswati's hands have not touched a single grain of sand, yet she has laid the structural foundation for the entire project. The modern building is erected first in the mind and the cloud, long before the concrete is poured.

‘The tools have evolved, and the hands are undeniably cleaner today. But a clean hand does not mean a resting body. The effort has simply migrated beneath the skin.’

For decades, the narrative has been that physical labor is dying in Mauritius. We look at the empty fishing boats on the shores of Trou d’Eau Douce, the quiet sugarcane fields or the quiet textile factories in Coromandel, and we observe the fading of a traditional era.

But the Mauritian working body has not retired; the tension has simply relocated.

The transition from the machete to the sensor, from the heavy shovel to the surveyor’s remote, traces the biological evolution of an island

over a single generation. The raw, muscular exhaustion endured by Rajan and Clifford laid the groundwork that now supports the precise, calculated movements of Yann and Saraswati. It is a quiet, continuous passing of the *baton*, where the rigorous physical toll of the past generations became the foundation for the technological pursuits of the next.

This shift reflects the changing anatomy of the Mauritian identity itself. It is not a rupture from the past, nor a rejection of it, but a logical continuation.

The landscape of labor has shifted indoors, the tools have evolved from bamboo to algorithms, and the hands are undeniably cleaner.

Yet, beneath these modern surfaces, the instinct to adapt, work, and secure a space in a rapidly globalizing world remains the constant thread connecting every generation.

The shape of Habits



National emblems are usually treated as flat images; printed on flags, stamped on coins, or woven into school uniforms. But a cultural identity is rarely just visual; it is something we physically inhabit. This collage is an observation of how the island subtly shapes the daily posture because to grow up in Mauritius is to absorb the environment.

*The **NBS bus** is not merely a vehicle; the sway of the chassis along the coastal roads teaches a collective balance with bodies naturally leaning together into the curve of the road. Similarly, the national anthem '**Mère Patrie**' is more than a melody; it is the learned stillness of a primary school courtyard as the flag is raised. Even the **Dodo**, our global avatar, is an anatomical story. We celebrate the silhouette of a bird defined by its heavy bones, a quiet reflection on vulnerability and the absolute necessity of adaptation.*

This is a map of small, subconscious physical habits. It reminds us that the Mauritian identity is not just a concept we inherit in our minds, but a familiar shape that our bodies naturally adopt.



The Choreography Of The Spine

National identity is rarely an abstract concept; in Mauritius, it is a physical record, written directly into the curvature of its people's spines. Over the span of a single century, the national posture has undergone a profound biomechanical transition. As the island shifted from the raw extraction of the earth to the digital architecture of the service industry, the physical center of gravity migrated upwards. This is the anatomy of a cultural adaptation.

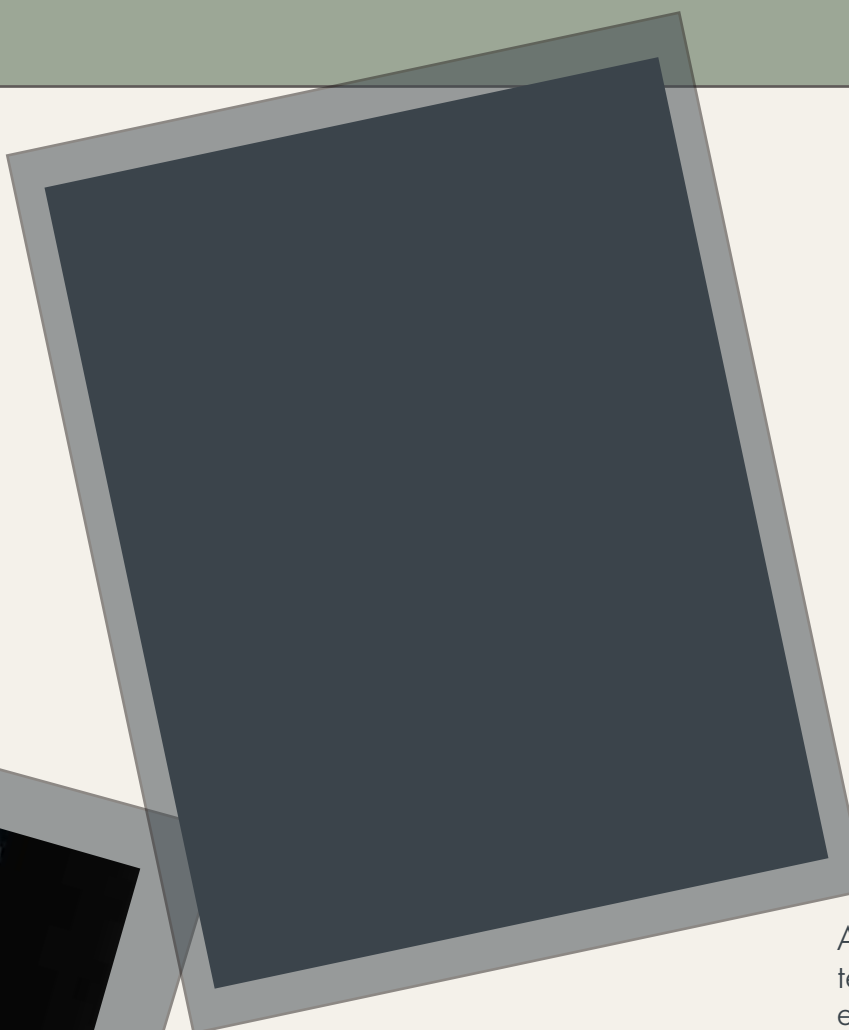
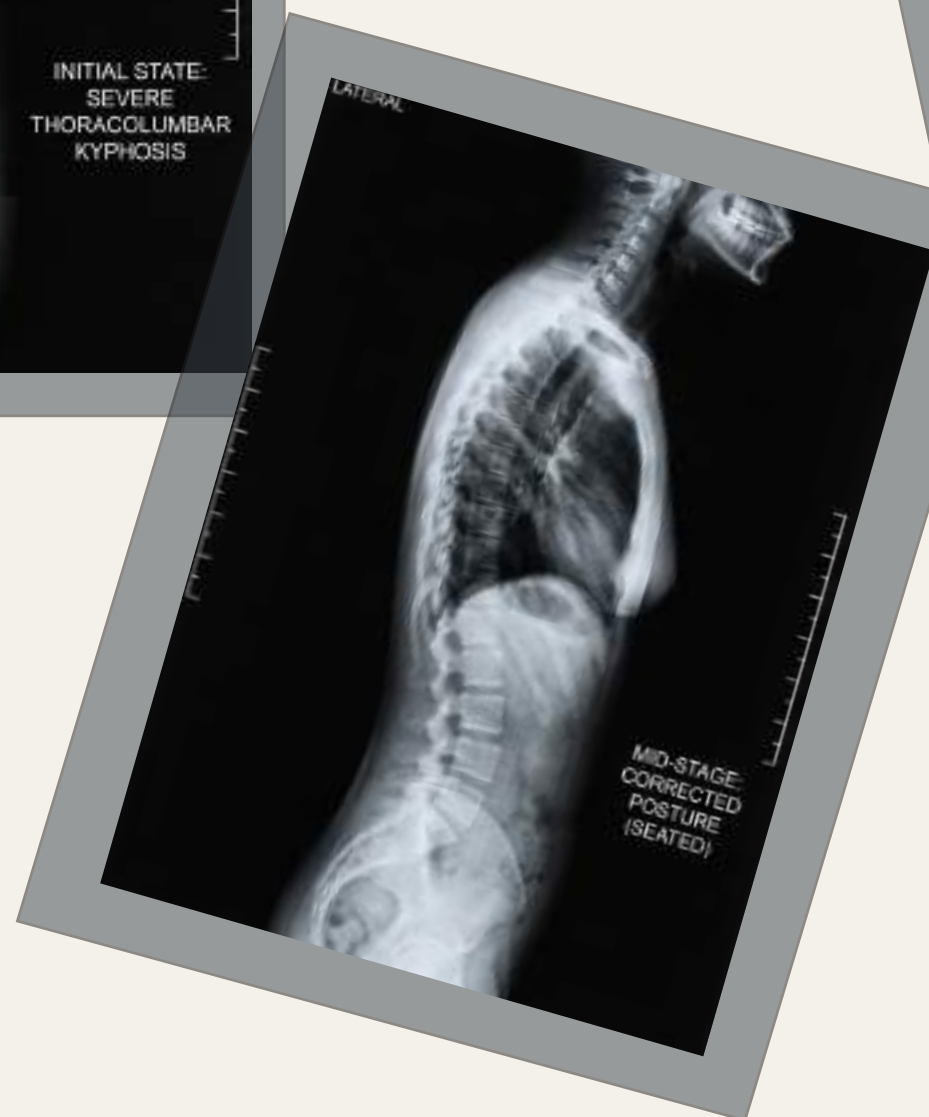


The Lower Back

Every Mauritian family tree, regardless of its origins, shares a common ancestral posture: the downward arc.

For the first centuries of its modern history, the island's economy necessitated a physical dialogue with the earth and the ocean. To harvest sugarcane, to pluck tea leaves in the damp heights of Curepipe, or to haul nets from the lagoon, the physical frame had to mirror the landscape. The Mauritian body was an organic extension of the soil, designed to close the distance between the human hand and the earth.

In this agricultural era, the center of gravity was kept low. The architectural foundation of the workforce was the lumbar spine, which absorbed the physical reality of the island's exports. To be Mauritian was to possess a back that knew the exact geometry of the terrain.



The Tensed Shoulders

As the island industrialized with the *Zone Franche* and the textile boom of the late 20th century, the posture of the economy transformed. The body moved indoors. For the first time on a mass scale, the Mauritian workforce was introduced to the geometry of the chair.

The spine straightened, transitioning from the fluid arc of the fields to the calculated angles of the workbench. The body aligned itself with the steady, metronomic pace of the sewing machines. The physical exertion did not vanish; it simply traveled upwards. Relieved of heavy lifting, the lower back ceded its role to the shoulders, the trapezius muscles, and the wrists. It was an era of calibrated stillness, where endurance was redefined as the ability to maintain perfect structural integrity in a confined space.



The Modern Neck

Today, the topography of Mauritian labor is not a single monolith, but a coexistence of postures. The downward arc of the fields and the static angle of the factories have not vanished; they remain the vital, physical anchors of the island's infrastructure. However, as the economy expanded into the service sector and the cybercities, a new, parallel alignment emerged.

For a growing segment of the population, the raw friction between flesh and raw materials has faded. The spine is now upright, often cradled by ergonomically optimized design. Yet, the human frame always finds a new axis. Observe the modern commuter waiting for the Metro Express: the spine is straight, but the cervical vertebrae pitch forward. The head is gently tilted down, drawn by the quiet, hypnotic pull of the digital screen.

The Continuous Threshold

For generations, the Mauritian body existed within a highly porous architecture. The boundaries between the private interior, the street, and the neighbor were fluid, requiring a constant, physical engagement with the environment. But as the island shifts toward climate-controlled interiors and digital agoras, the physical threshold is disappearing.

How does the Mauritian body occupy a space that no longer breathes?

There was a time when the Mauritian identity was inescapably physical, anchored entirely to the immediate radius of the neighborhood. The two vital organs of this local universe were the shaded, semi-open gallery of the home we named **the Varangue** and **the Boutique Sinoi**, the ubiquitous corner shop smelling of fresh bread, spices, and damp wood.

These spaces functioned as our original social networks. They were not closed rooms, but open zones of contact that required the body to be physically present. To participate in the Mauritian **art of palabre**, basically gossiping, was to engage in high physical friction. You stood shoulder-to-shoulder in the tropical heat of the shop, or you sat on the varangue, your skin in direct contact with the humid air and the noise of the street. It was an era of eye contact, expressive hands, and shifting weight, where the pulse of the community was felt just as much as it was heard.



Today, the architecture of our connection is fundamentally changing. Those faded blue wooden doors and open galleries are gently giving way to the expansive, air-conditioned volumes of modern living. We are trading the open boundaries of the past for the hermetic box: floor-to-ceiling windows, aluminum frames, and internal climate control.

This transition is not a loss of comfort, but a radical shift in our spatial geometry. The neighborhood conversation has not died; it has simply outgrown the street corner, taking flight into the digital ether. But the posture of the Mauritian social body has changed. We now gather by the thousands in sprawling commercial food courts like **Tribeca** or **Bagatelle**, yet our eyes are cast downward. The point of contact with the world is no longer a shared physical space; it is a glass screen. The body has moved from the open gallery, where it actively touched the air of the island, to the sealed interior, where it is shielded from it. Physically isolated, yet negotiating a boundless digital proximity.



Q: How did the physical boundaries of your neighborhood dictate your social space?

THE MATRIARCH: 'The neighborhood was an open room. Hindu, Muslim, Creole, and Chinese lived shoulder-to-shoulder but a woman's body was strictly governed by the specific beliefs of her own courtyard. Space was controlled because there were no closed doors, everyone watched your every step. A young woman loitering on the street was a scandalous public event, constantly monitored by a community desperate to preserve its distinct cultural lines.'

THE GEN Z: 'I am connected to my neighborhood through my phone, and there's no ethnic or religious zoning. I meet my peers online first, and when we gather physically, it's usually at the shopping mall. The street doesn't watch me because the mall offers the physical freedom of a crowd without the burden of ancestral surveillance. We mix effortlessly because the old territorial boundaries do not exist in the digital space.'

Q: How did this proximity affect the concept of reputation and the Mauritian 'palabre'?

THE MATRIARCH: 'Reputation was a physical weight you carried daily, and it was deeply tied to our faith. The palabre was an architectural reality; if the old grandmas were talking about you at the *boutique sinoi*, you had to physically hide your face and carry the judgment of the entire parish, the temple, the pagoda, or the mosque on your shoulders every time you crossed the threshold of your home.'

THE GEN Z: 'Because I don't need to defend my reputation to protect my family's standing, the palabre today is just digital noise. If people talk on a feed, I simply block them. I can control the exact boundaries of my audience; my grandmother couldn't just close the varangue to the whispers of the congregation.'

Q: Ultimately, in these different spaces, who claims ownership of the physical body?

THE MATRIARCH: 'In my time, a woman's physical body was a collective, spiritual asset. Whenever I was draped in a sari, covered by a dupatta, or dressed modestly for Sunday mass, the way I dressed was a reflection of the family's honor. My flesh was not my own; it was a protected archive belonging to the community.'

THE GEN Z: 'My body is sovereign territory. The ink on my arm is what I make of it, there's no religious meaning if I don't want to. It is an aesthetic choice, not a communal mandate. The modern Mauritian woman's body is no longer a religious vessel or a cultural battleground. Because I am free from the street's gaze, my flesh is an independent canvas, curated exclusively for myself.'



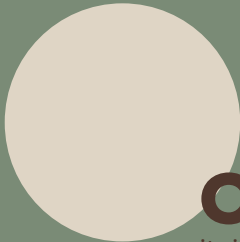


Where does the Mauritian body go now to observe the world? The gallery has not been demolished; it has simply decentralized. We still monitor the pulse of our diverse communities, but our neighborhood is no longer defined by walking distance. We have traded the localized friction of the corner shop for a boundless digital proximity.

The Mauritian social body has not retreated; it has expanded.

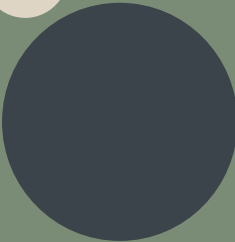
In this light, the Matriarch and the Gen Z are not ideological opposites, but two responses to a changing environment. The Grandmother engaged with the tight perimeter of the street because geographic proximity was her survival. The Granddaughter curates a borderless feed today as the ultimate anchor is individual autonomy.

Both women practice the exact same cultural reflex: the profound Mauritian instinct to adapt and thrive within the available space.



Our identity is not a fragile artifact meant for the glass of nostalgia; it is an ongoing biomechanical mutation. We have stood up from the soil, washed our hands, and adapted to the climate-controlled interiors. Yet, the essential, restless energy of the island remains.

As we close this dossier, we do not mourn the physical spaces we have outgrown. We observe a body in continuous motion. The threshold between us and the world has not vanished, it has merely taken a new form, waiting for us to master its next choreography.



The End

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Reflection & Ending note

Throughout the pages of BASALT, we have attempted a complex excavation of the Mauritian identity. We have explored the volcanic soil that anchored us, the history that was transmitted from one generation to another, the cultural currents that shaped our minds, and finally, in the closing dossier, the very flesh and bone that carried the weight of our evolution.

If this magazine has proven one thing, it is that the Mauritian identity is not a static relic meant to be preserved under glass. It is a living, breathing architecture. It is a continuous, relentless choreography of adaptation.

But as the analytical lens zooms out, and the sociological blueprint of the island is finally drawn, a profound silence settles over the page.

What remains beyond the grand narratives of cultural and economic shifts? When the tools rest, the feeds go dark, and the architecture fades, we are left with the unyielding fragility of the human form. It is the private heart that bears the island's true weight. We build grand institutions hoping to outlast our mortality, yet our purest essence escapes the public square to reside in the quiet intimacy of a family home. The body is only the vessel. It is the spirit, that sharp-witted, deeply rooted Mauritian essence, that defies the silence.

To officially close this exploration, I decided to step away from the collective and step into the deeply personal. Leave the street, cross the final threshold, and observe the space where the heavy, public armor is finally unbuckled, allowing the private flesh to rest.

An Homage

How do we reconcile the men who build our institutions with the men who sit at our Sunday tables? As we reach the final pages of BASALT, we turn the lens inward to observe a final duality: the public armor and the private self. This is a tribute to Bruno Dumazel, President of the Alliance Française, Freemason, and Knight of the Order of Academic Palms. But more importantly, a tribute to «Tonton Bruno.»

There is a concept in medieval political theology known as 'The King's Two Bodies'. It dictates that a ruler possesses a body natural (mortal, subject to disease, fatigue, and death) and a body politic (immortal, representing the institution).

Growing up in Mauritius, I learned that this concept does not only apply to kings. It applies to the individuals who quietly hold the architecture of our island together.

To the outside world, my uncle carried the weight of a Body Politic. Bruno Dumazel, the President of the Alliance Française. Bruno Dumazel, Knight of the Order of Academic Palms by the French Republic. Bruno Dumazel, Grand Master of Freemasonry. Bruno Dumazel, the renowned land surveyor.

When he moved through Port-Louis, he was a man of protocol, syntax, and gravity. His public posture was draped in suits, medals, and Masonic regalia. He shook hands with ambassadors, sat on corporate boards, and delivered speeches while adapting to an island that is constantly shifting.

When I looked at him in those official settings, I did not see my uncle; I saw a pillar of the Mauritian establishment.

But the Body Politic is heavy, and every architecture has a private interior.

The transformation happened on Sundays. The doors of the Alliance Française were locked, the Masonic lodge was silent, and the suit was replaced by a simple, loose and old dress shirt. The institution vanished, leaving only the man.

This was the Body Natural. The flesh-and-blood Mauritian uncle. Behind the closed gates at Tamarin, facing the quiet expanse of the Baie, he would sit calmly, observing the room amid the familiar motion of nieces, nephews, and siblings. The gravity of the Grand Master softened into playful jokes and the calm, observant eyes of a man who simply loved to eat, drink, and live.

Here, he did not discuss land contracts; he argued passionately about the proper seasoning of a 'civet de canard' or the latest 'palabré'. His hands, which on weekdays signed official documents, were now busy pouring wine for his family.

As a child, this duality fascinated me. How could the man who embodied the formal rules of the Republic be the same man making us laugh at the Sunday table?

It is perhaps the ultimate paradox of the Mauritian identity. We are an island of people who wear grand institutional masks to navigate a globalized world, but who only truly let our shoulders rest when we return to the lakour. Bruno Dumazel mastered both. He gave his intellect to the public, but he kept his heart, and his real flesh, for us.



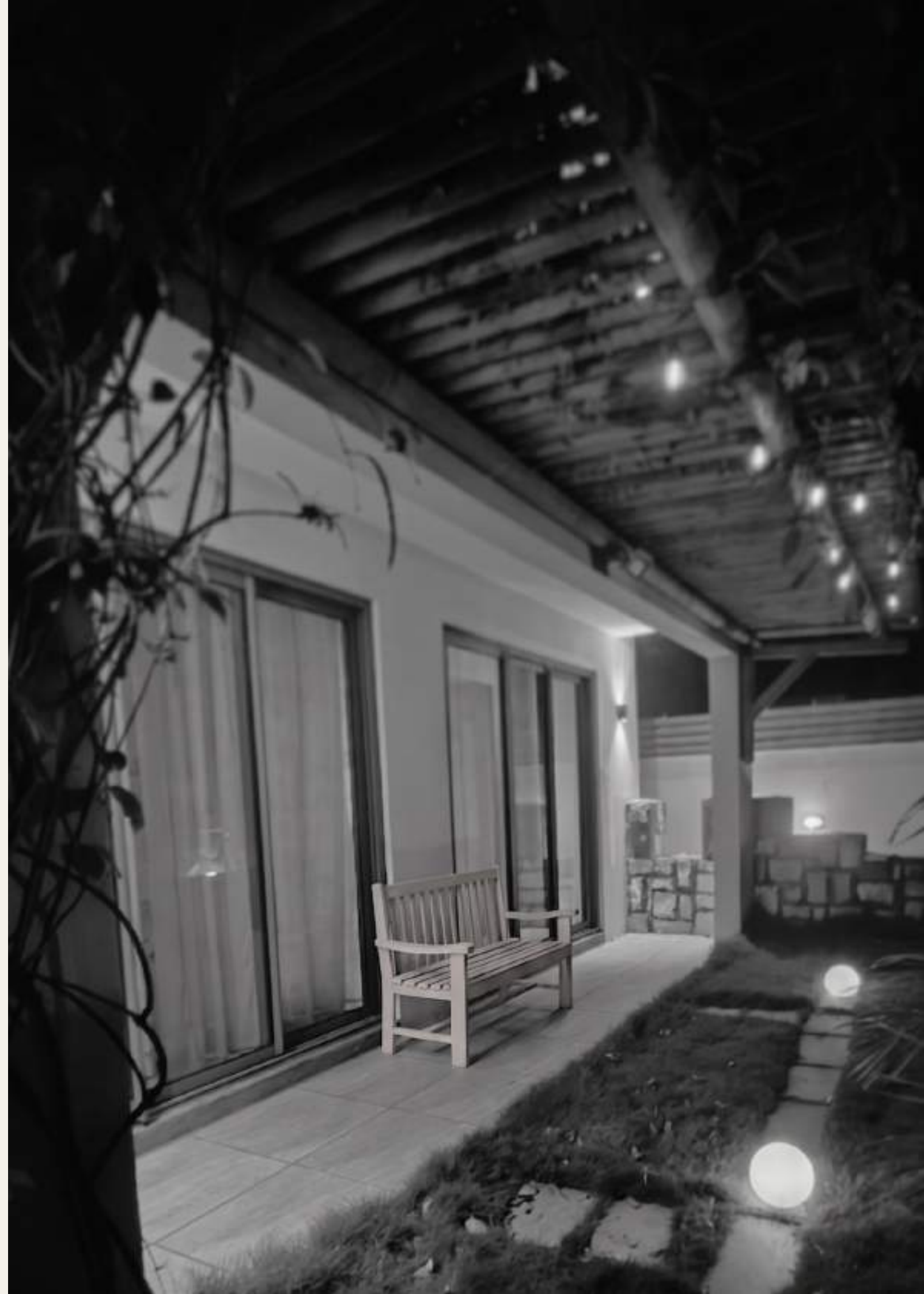
Inevitably, the Body Natural finally gave way to come to rest.

When the news of Bruno Dumazel's passing broke, the island reacted to the loss of the Body Politic. The French Embassy issued official letters of condolence. Institutions lowered their flags. The newspapers published obituaries honoring the notable man and the cultural architect. They mourned the loss of a great mind.

But at our table, we mourned the loss of the flesh. We did not cry for the President of the Alliance Française; we cried because the chair at the head of the Sunday table was empty. We cried because the jokes and the booming laugh were gone, and because the hands that poured the wine were finally still.

To close the pages of this magazine is to accept a quiet truth. The grand institutions we build will predictably outlive us. The Body Politic is written into the archives, immortal. But the true, unspoken essence of the Mauritian identity is mortal, ephemeral, and fiercely private. It is not found in the titles we accumulate, but in the people we gather around the table. It exists in the comforting rhythm of our shared language, and the smile of an uncle on a Sunday afternoon.

Adieu, Monsieur le Président. Et bon voyage, Tonton.



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Légende : *b* = bas, *h* = haut, *g* = gauche, *d* = droite

Photographies

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